

Fatunik Dominion

The Fatunik Authority

The morning bell rings from the Shining Temple of Fatune, its bronze voice rolling across Beshquahoek's curved streets before first light like a physical thing. In the brooder houses that fill the eastern quarter, women rise in darkness, their breath visible in the cold air, and begin the day's song. It's a simple melody, one their mothers sang and their grandmothers before them, about the certainty of dawn. The words promise warmth, order, the return of the Inextinguishable.

Outside their shuttered windows, the Watch is changing shifts, boots scuffing cobblestone, low voices exchanging passwords.

This is the Fatunik Dominion. Not all of it by any means. The Fatunik provinces stretch from the mouth of the Settan River to the wilds of Wesshewen, from the borders of the United Rider Provinces to the ancient eastern towns. Beshquahoek, a gleaming fortress-city with undulating walls that catch the rising sun like waves frozen in stone, is where the heart of the Dominion. It is where Authority speaks, where Tonedor Rumpet, Grand Tagabant of the New Fatunik Authority, has remade the Dominion in his image.

Or tried to, anyway.

Walk these curved streets as Fatune climbs and you'll see what sixty-five years of reformation can accomplish. The great plaza radiates order. Stalls are arranged in perfect arcs, each vendor in their prescribed location, Day Watchers are positioned at intervals marked by brass studs in the pavement.

The Great Temple rises at the center, its spire catching Fatune's first

light, a daily demonstration of the teachings of the Noonday Scribes: that all illumination descends from above, that hierarchy mirrors the cosmos, and that the moons and stars are but holes in night's fabric through which darkness leaks, unless good order keeps it at bay.

A rag-clad rabbit-sint servant sweeps the temple steps each morning. Old Tesh paws work the broom in practiced strokes as his limps through his tasks. If you ask him about his life ,he'll tell you it's better now, at 35 turns (old for a rabbit-sint) than when he was young. Better than his father and grandfather had it . Here he has a clearly assigned place, with a semblance of protection, and the certainty of hot meal once or even twice a week. A minor Temple staffer once cuffed him hard enough to knock him down the steps for humming a tune while working, breaking his leg. It reminds him of what separates the Blessed Lands from what lurks beyond its borders. Here the order of things is clear. He knows his place. And Tesh will tell you, with something resembling pride, that no-one has publicly beaten him in many turns.

For the rabbit-sints, the Dominion offers survival inside of a structure, a steady order extracted out of centuries of bleeding. Tesh doesn't think about whether it's right or wrong that he and the other rabbit-sints are ordered to sweep the plaza in silence during the early morning chill. He thinks about the carrots hidden under the straw pallet where he sleeps in the servants' bunkers, hoping that a night-working day sleeper hasn't discovered his stash.

It is all Tesh has ever known and he feels that it is, if not just, at least certain.

But if you ask Tesh's sister Alysh about her children.... And ask her privately, when the Dorq Tagabant patrol has moved along to the next street. You'll hear something in her voice. A flatness. Her children were taken away as soon as they could walk and she has not seen

them since. The Noonday Scribes say this ensures they'll grow in Fatune's light, free from corrupting intimacies. She'll nod when they say this because to do otherwise would invite retribution. Then she'll mutter an old song that the Watchers can't hear. Huum have such small ears. And at night, squeezed into her narrow space in between other rabbit workers, she sometimes weeps for reasons she can't quite name.

The Weight of History

The Fatunik Dominion did not spring wholly-formed from Tonedor Rumpet's ambitions, though listening to the New Authority's pronouncements you might think otherwise. No. Its roots run deep into time. Back to the original huum settlements of the Saskan Lands at the conclusion of the Great Migration. back to the founding of Ingar town. Two thousand turns back, when the first of the Eibar Folk gathered around the Book of Heliohdamus and decided that huum, unchanged, unmodified, pure, in their original form, just as they had been during the long centuries down below, had been given the responsibility to inherit what remained of the surface world.

The Book itself, an ancient text said to have been written just before the catastrophe, speaks in metaphors about light and darkness, about the corruption that comes from mixing what should remain separate, about the great fire storms that wiped away the evil ones. And about the glorious tomorrow that awaits the faithful. At the arrival, the early settlers of Ingar were fisher-folk and farmers, refugees from the down below, survivors of the great migration who scratched a meagre living from rocky soil and a roiling river they dubbed the Pavan (the source) in a new land they called Saskantinon (the land between the rivers).

They found comfort in the Book's promises and they found purpose in

its warnings.

The riders who had accompanied them on the great migration out of the blasted lands abandoned them soon after the founding of Ingar, heading upriver, far to the west, to form their own settlement. Connections between the Fatunik walkers of the long march and their mounted protectors and guides were weakened. Responsible then for their own defences, they turned Ingar into a formidable fortress and a center of Fatunik authority.

Ingar's Fatunik Authority was simply what a council of elders started to call themselves. Then it grew into institutions that were more watchful, more proactive, more comprehensive. Renamed the Council of the Eibar Folk, Ingar's leaders took aim at anything that threatened the fragile order they were building. The Council crafted, developed and refined their institutions over the course of several centuries of growth and expansion. The Day Watch for visible transgression, the Night Watch for the hidden kind. The Riverwaq to keep an eye on those arriving from upriver or downriver bearing ideas that might throw shade on the light of Fatune. The Front Tagabant (warriors) defended the frontiers. And the Dorq (daily) Tagabant kept good order in the town and the expanding array of local villages.

For hundreds of turns, the Council of the Eibar Folk protected Fatunik Authority from Ingar town. The town grew, the great Holly Tree at its center became the core of its tower. The province of Eibar grew to over 37,000 square kilometers of river valley, farm, land and rising hills stretching north from Ingar to feed and support the Bar-speaking hum. Along with many small villages, two market towns sprouted up on the periphery of Ingar, at the crossroads where paths beginning to turn into roads led upriver, towards the hills, in the direction the Riders has gone, and downriver, heading towards the sea.

A group of Ingar explorers had followed the river all the way to the mouth of the Pavan River. There they created a new town that looked out towards the sea. They called it Blubar (eye of the Bar folk), but

now we call it -- for reasons we'll explain later -- Pavanoa, in the new coastal province of Pavanarune.

While the Eibar and Pavanarune settlements grew quickly, hum folk continued to explore the Saskan lands. The next major out-migration consisted of hundreds of hum who, having been denounced by the Council for their contrariness to the Book, retreated into the deep forest on the other side of the river. They did not go far, no further than the distance between Ingar and Blubar. But the separation was so complete that the Council of the Eibar Folk referred to them as Kahila (the lost ones).

As expansion and discovery and dispersal of the hum population accelerated, the authority of the Council of the Eibar Folk at Ingar began to wane. Though Ingar and Blubar had strong ties of trade and exchange, the coastal town and its surrounding province of Pavanarune took on a considerably more open feeling than Eibar. Kahila folk visited the coastal areas and it did not cause a panic. Solemn rites at the Temple of Fatune in Blubar were less well attended than enthusiastic festivals of the fishes held down by the docks.

And another major town had been founded. Some 500 kilometers westward, not along the river, but further south, in the stubborn, timeworn hills of the central Saskan highlands. In that mist-drowned maze of limestone gorges and moss-choked hollows, where ferns grow tall as saplings, pioneers had found roots gripping ancient ruins around the collapsed roof of an underground pool.

And around that pool, on top of those ruins, they founded the town of Juuj (judgement).

The town became a center for discussion. Its debates evolved into scholarly explorations of the Book of Heliohdamus, at a level that had never been seen in Ingar. Slow, careful, unassailable scholarship, and

new texts were preserved on vellum scrolls. Along with a slow accretion of influence, the Elders of Juuj oversaw the growth of a new province they called Juukal (forest of justice). Without any particular moment of transformation, Juuj grew into the seat of Fatunik Authority that now encompassed Eibar, Pavanarune and Juukal provinces. Along its quickly-growing periphery, the first encounters with non-huum sentient lifeforms (sints) were taking place, Under the leadership of the Elders of Juuj, with Fatunik expansion increasingly blocked by entrenched sint warrens, villages, encampments and hunting grounds on their frontiers, the entire region under their influence came to be called the Fatunik Dominion.

The ancient stones of Juuj, though overgrown with more roots and vines than ever before, are still visible. The vastly expanded caverns around the Deep Pool still host the Elders of Juuj, who continue to pursue their studies. But now they too, like the Council of the Eibar Folk, who also continue to meet inside the Holly Tower of Ingar, are just leaders of another second-tier provincial town with an interesting history. These days any meaningful *decisions* flow from Beshquahoek, the undisputed Center of the New Fatunik Authority, located even further to the west.

The ascendancy of Beshquahoek came quickly, when the Kahila Troubles were put to an end. The antagonism between the Eibar and Kahila folk had grown worse and worse, culminating in three centuries of grinding conflict that pitted the Dominion against the forested provinces that had grown to occupy some 75,000 square kilometers between the Pavan and the second great Saskan river, the Settan (mother of the waters), further to the south. The Kahila lands had attracted sint sympathizers and vegetarians , star-gazers and moons worshipers, and every other type of criminal heretic who refused to accept Fatunik Authority. And to make matters worse, they were proud of it.

When the Eibar folk started to push on their frontier, the Kahila

pushed back.

From the Fatunik perspective, the Kahila were trying to shut out the light of Fatune. They had also grown quite numerous over the centuries of separation. From their forest redoubts, they had become fine fighters and trackers, often faster and stealthier than their Tagabant foes. The fighting flared up, died down, then re-ignited a thousand times. While the Dominion was expanding rapidly to the west, eventually encountering the thriving Rider territories and the strongholds of the mountain-dwelling Eelani, their eastern frontiers expanded barely a centimeter. Huum settlements had been founded further to the south, to be sure, but the Outer Lands were never really secured by the Tagabant. Beyond the neighboring zones, the Dominion could and did send large-scale expeditionary forces aimed at driving out the animal-sints. But actually holding on to the wild lands of Ny, much less Arq, was always a fool's errand.

Out west, the Eelani, who were an early offshoot from the Rider's westward migration, made no secret of their complete disdain for the Fatunik Dominion. Their taunting of the Eibar folk and of their foundational Book and ever-growing collection of Scrolls made the Kahila's refusal to respect Fatune's light look like child's play. Conflict erupted when the Elders of Juuj, believing that the miners would retreat as quickly as the animal-sints had in the southern lands, decided to teach the Eelani a lesson. It was a tragedy: a war of conquest became a stymied war of attrition at great cost to both sides. The Eelani-Fatunik War, the most brutal conflict ever seen in the Saskan lands, ended with a great conflagration whose scars still burn in the memory of the Fatunik folk of the Borda Woods (westernmost Dominion province. Even now, two hundred turns later, relations between the Dominion and the miners of Eelan remain fraught.

Before and during *that* traumatic episode, and for another two hundred turns, the troubles with the Kahila continued to erupt in the border settlements of the eastern frontier. Murders, thefts, retributions; a cycle of violence with no end in sight. Their inability to

seize a single stone as a result of the great war of conquest against the Eelani had been a shock to the Elders of Juuj. To make matters worse, it had brought the Riders and the Eelani closer together. Trying to do better in the case of the Kahila conflict, the Elders debated and considered and negotiated and apologized and threatened and ignored and made proclamations. But they never again launched a massive attack as they had in the south and the west.

And the troubles never stopped.

Until Tonedor Rumpet, the self-proclaimed Grand Tagabant, ended the Troubles in six months. In a sudden and overwhelming assault on the Kahilaqor, the less deeply forested corridor connecting the two main Kahila-populated zones, his forces swept in like a pack of wild coyotes. The Kahila campaign is remembered in taverns throughout the Fatunik Dominion with equal parts pride and discomfort. The Dominion "won", decisively. On the heels of the slaughter, the great general declared that the Authority of the Elders of Juuj was over, that the old ways were insufficient for the modern age. On the day that the leading chiefs of Kahilabeq surrendered (the Kahilakol never surrendered; they just withdrew deeper into the forest), he proclaimed the Beshquo Reforms and initiated the construction of Beshquahoek.

The New Center of Fatunik Authority was built in ten turns. Its undulating double walls, ten meters high, were constructed by conscripted labor pulled in from every Fatunik province. The main avenues of Beshquahoek (meaning, roughly, "order and power" in Eibar) are laid out in gracefully curving mathematically-precise arcs. The plaza is designed so that when Fatune's light strikes its spire at high noon, the Shining Temple of Fatune casts no shadow. The New Authority does not sponsor debates about ancient texts of doubtful origins. It acts. It transforms landscapes. It brings the light of Fatune into every corner of the Dominion and beyond, into every aspect of

life.

To be sure, suspicious cracks are forming around the foundations of the Temple's façade. And not all the stories about the great accomplishments of the New Authority are told *completely*. For example, it is never mentioned in official histories of the town that Beshquahoek was designed, and its construction managed, entirely by well-paid engineers from Byenung, a town in the Outer Lands beyond the control of the Dominion.

The Architecture of Control

The Fatunik Authority at Beshquahoek is a hierarchy as intricate as the city's street plan. At the apex sits the Grand Tagabant, Tonedor Rumpet, now approaching ninety years old but still sharp as worked flint. Below him: the High Council of Watchers, the Scribal Orders, the Tagabant Commands. Within the Tagabant are military units named for provinces and functions, each with their own traditions and jealousies.

The Tagabant aren't a unified force. The Eibar Tagabant, named for the oldest northeastern provinces, pride themselves on discipline and endurance. Their barracks smell of oil and boiled grain. They were the battalions who pacified the southern lands, and who have protected the Dominion for centuries against incursions from Ilyushan. The Khaliro Tagabant, stationed at their great fortress on the Pavan, maintain the river crossings and extract tolls from merchants. They are admired as the source of the fiercest troops for the Front Tagabant, serving on the northern frontier, protecting the Dominion from the Weshewen barbarians. But they also have reputation for a certain venality, a willingness to look the other way when the coin is right. The Beshquo Tagabant, Rumpet's own creation and based in his capital, answer directly to the Grand Tagabant and serve as enforcers when the other units prove insufficiently zealous. The Meyajo (inner eye) Tagabant, the Dominion's secret police, are a branch of the

Beshquo regiment.

Then there are the Fatunik Volunteers, a name that once meant something different. Originally created by regular townsfolk and villagers responding to emergency calls from the Council of the Eibar Folk, they were exactly that: Eibar folk who took up arms or did the gruelling work of recovery during extreme times. That Volunteer tradition still exists, but now mainly outside of the Dominion itself, in the provinces of the so-called Outer Lands, where a variety of Fatunik faith exists outside the norms of the Center. But within the Dominion, the name 'Fatunik Volunteer' now applies to shock troops recruited to raid heretical gatherings, burn prohibited texts, and march through occupied territories planting Fatunik banners. Youth as young as fourteen can join. The promise of status, of regular meals, of a purpose larger than their individual lives, and an opportunity to feel powerful proves sufficient inducement for recruitment.

A Volunteer named Korvin, holding fifteen turns and no trade name, stands post near the western gate of Beshquahoek on a cold morning in late autumn. He's been in service eight months. His leather armor fits poorly across the shoulders. He watches the road that leads towards the Borda Woods and the Eelani and Rider territories beyond, and his hand resting on the cudgel at his belt. There are no blades for Volunteers, not until they've proven themselves in three testings, and even then they need to find the aybets to buy one.

A mixt woman pulling a small cart approaches. Her face shows subtle asymmetries marking a reshaped, not entirely huum bloodline. She's from Barból, the great southern market town on the other side of the Settan. The southerners travel to Dominion towns to to sell their herbs. Her stamps are in order. The Dorq Tagabant has checked them twice already and waved her through. But when she approaches Korvin, he makes her wait while he inspects her bundles, making her feel the weight of his authority as he rifles through them, making sure she understands she's here on sufferance.

She keeps her eyes down. Says nothing. Her hands don't shake and her gaze is steady. There is something in her posture, a careful stillness, a fearlessness, a surety, that Korvin recognizes without naming. It makes him feel powerful and uncomfortable in equal measure. He waves her on eventually, leaving her to reassemble the goods herself. He tells himself he's protecting the Light. That someone has to guard the boundaries between pure and corrupted, between the Faithful and the heretics. He has a hint of suspicion that the Dorq Tagabant might be getting lax.

Later, the herbalist from Barból sells her bundles quickly and below fair price. She wants to be gone before the afternoon inspection. She feels safer being on the road after dark. A Fatunik brood mother buys a bundle of feverfew and doesn't meet the seller's eyes, ashamed and grateful in confusing proportion, then slips her an extra half-aybet over the agreed price without saying a word, only a quick glance to affirm it was not a mistake. Everybody knows the Settan herbs work much better than anything the Fatunik herbalists guild has to offer. Everyone knows this. But no one says it aloud.

The Gleam and the Grime

There's a peculiar doubling to life inside the Dominion. On one hand: the pageantry, the certainty, the gleaming spire in Beshquahoek that catches Fatune's first light. The morning songs in the brooder houses genuinely bring comfort. The Watches and the Tagabant do prevent certain kinds of chaos. When raiders from Wesshewen threaten the northern borders, it is mainly Fatunik troops, with some help from the Rider Arms, who turn them back. When famine struck the north-eastern provinces twelve years ago, it was centralized Fatunik grain reserves that prevented mass starvation among the hum population.

The Authority enforces traditional hierarchies via strict protocols, and that solves a certain class of problems. Population control in a world

of scarcity isn't optional; it's survival. The regulated procreation and child-rearing system, the brooder houses and careful monitoring of breeding cycles: these prevent the kind of demographic collapse that, according to the Book, swallowed previous civilizations.

The Noonday Scribes explain it as honoring Fatune by following the instructions of the Book of Heliohdamus, as interpreted by the Grand Tagabant. Ordinary folk understand it as the price of not starving.

On the other hand there are the prison cells at Beet, a fortress-town in the northern highlands where the Fatunik Authority sends dissidents and heretics. Iron cages are open to the elements. The smell of waste and desperation is everywhere. Guards have learned not to hear the screaming. Some have learned to enjoy it. A merchant from Pavanarune, caught with Mobali astronomical charts, spends three years at Beet before dying of fever. His crime: suggesting that the stars might be distant suns similar to Fatune. His punishment is systematic and instructive.

Walk the docks at Pavanoa, far to the east where the Authority's grip on the Dominion is looser, and you'll hear different songs. The longshoremen wait until the Tagabant patrol passes, then resume their conversations. They speak carefully, voices low, but they speak. About the days when the Center of Authority was at Juuj, or even at Ingar. About traders from beyond the Krbsh Sea who bring news of places where modified hum live openly, where the weirdly subservient Jaxen folk aren't hunted down, and where the worship of Fatune is optional rather than mandatory. Or stranger still, where it is entirely unheard-of.

One retired docker, white-bearded and missing two fingers from a loading accident, remembers the days before Beshquahoek was built, before the Reforms, when heretic-burnings were rare, not annual events. Educational, the Fatunik Scribes called them back then. Necessary demonstrations of Fatune's punishment for evil-doers. Now they've become almost festive. The last Gleaming in Beshquahoek's great plaza drew thousands. Vendors sold roasted nuts. Children were lifted onto parents' shoulders for better views. The screaming didn't

last long. The New Authority had gotten efficient about accelerating the process. But the smell lingers for days.

"Here comes Fatune," someone sang that morning at the start of the Gleaming, and the crowd took it up. It's an old children's rhyme. Here comes the warmth, little one. Here comes the light, sleep tight. The melody is genuinely beautiful. The harmonies work. This is perhaps the most disturbing thing about the Dominion: how much of its horror comes wrapped in aesthetic pleasure, in the satisfaction of order and stability, in the relief of knowing your place and keeping to it.

The Provinces and Their Particulars

The Dominion spreads across a geography as varied as its population. In the vast northern woodlands around Sungyte, a Tower rises above the ancient forests, its watchfires visible for miles. The lumber trade feeds Fatunik construction projects. The foresters who work these woods are hard folk, as they like to call themselves. They are believers in ascetic codes that would frowned-upon in the core provinces: vegetable-eaters who nonetheless enforce Fatunik doctrine with their own quiet ferocity.

In the southeast part of the Dominion, where the Pavan River flows towards the Krbsh Sea, the provinces of Pavanarune and Eibar stretch across some of the most fertile farmland in the Saskan Lands. They are the breadbasket regions, the source of the grain reserves that keep the Dominion fed in hard times. The farmers here work to rhythms older than the Dominion itself, planting by the moons' complex phases despite official prohibition against moons-reckoning. The New Authority looks the other way as long as quotas are met.

The old centers maintain their own characters. Juuj, with its ancient fortress-temple and Council of Elders that still imagines themselves

relevant. Ingar on the Pavan, upriver from the coast, the first seat of authority, now a bustling port where the smells and sounds of the turbulent river corrode everyone's certainty. Pavanoa, facing the sea, looking away from the Center. Pavanarune and Ingar, eastern bastions whose distance from Beshquahoek breeds something resembling autonomy.

In Khālo province, the great fortress of Khaliro guards the Pavan's major crossing and hosts the famous Khālo Bridge, symbol of the Tagabant. The troops stationed there have grown wealthy on tolls and bribes and supply systems for the frontier guards. The town of Khaliro has developed a reputation for pragmatism that borders on organized corruption. They'll enforce Fatunik law strictly on some days, selectively on others, depending on factors ordinary resident and visitors find hard to predict. So many of the towns residents are involved in the system, it is hard to say where, or if, it is breaking down the Fatunik order or creating a new version of it. This unpredictability serves its own purpose. It keeps everyone nervous, compliant, hoping to avoid notice, in many cases hoping not to lose their cut.

The neighboring territories to south, called "the Outer Lands" by Dominion folk, are a mystery to many. Mobalbesq with its fire-cults nominally integrated into Fatunik doctrine but clearly following a very distinct path. The Kahila Corridor, still occupied and still troubled sixty years after the wars ended. Then there are the Runes of Bye, who have been sending learned Arguments to the Elders of Juuj since time immemorial, implying that it is they, in their blasphemously-named Night Hall, and not the Fatunik Authority, who truly stand in the light.

In those contested spaces and beyond, the Fatunik authority, if it has a hand at all, remains military rather than cultural. The towns of Mobalbesq and the Runes of Bye fly Fatunik banners when their Volunteers gather in the squares to celebrate the light in their own fashion, not because they have internalized the teachings of any of the incarnations of the Fatunik Authority.

Cracks in the Foundation

Tonedor Rumpet's genius was recognizing that the Fatunik Dominion survived the Kahila Troubles by accident as much as by virtue. The old Authority at Juuj had been weakening, its control fragmenting, its ideology becoming hollow performance, even since the stalemate that ended the Fatunik-Eelani War. Rumpet offered renewal: a return to ancient boundaries (proclaimed, never actually held), a revitalization of (rediscovered, newly promulgated) true purpose, and an end to the drift toward accommodation, compromise and autonomy.

In their way, his reforms were a huge success. The construction of Beshquahoek gave the faithful a physical manifestation of power and permanence. The expansion of Tagabant units provided employment and structure for thousands of young hum who, lacking a trade and unwilling to hunt or work the fields, might otherwise have turned to banditry or rebellion. The new and refurbished temples and monuments, the Volunteer schools, the systematic indoctrination of young children in the communal brooding centers; all of this created a generation more thoroughly Fatunik than their parents or grandparents.

But the foundation is showing stress fractures.

The New Authority lacks unanimous support even within the Dominion's core provinces. The expansion of the Grand Tagabant's power came at the expense of the old councils, the traditional hierarchies. Not only the former Centers of Authority, but the provincial, municipal and village authorities who'd grown accustomed to a large degree of autonomy. Many of those displaced by a centralized power bow and scrape publicly while undermining reform privately and quietly. Food quotas get misreported. Prohibited scrolls circulate in coded networks. Broodkins disappear into extended family households deep in the countryside, retrieved by relatives whom the Watchers can't easily track.

The paranoia grows. More cells are constructed at Beet. More Watchers are recruited from the Volunteers. The zealotry of the

youngsters makes them reliable but their inexperience makes them brutal. More burnings, more displays, more public demonstrations of power: they reveal the New Authority's anxiety as much as its strength.

And the external pressures have not gone away. The Riders in Bordered grow steadily stronger, not weaker, their cavalry forces better-equipped with Eelani steel that is superior to Fatunik weapons. The herbalist-healers of the Settan Lands develop medicines that far outperform Fatunik-approved treatments, creating black market demands that the Watchers can't suppress. The engineers of Byenung, Mobalbesq, Terpinol and Eelan create tools, techniques and machines that the Fatunik Scribes don't understand and can't replicate.

And now... the Untamed. Sentient animals whom the Fatuniks dismiss as corrupted mistakes, are organizing in ways that aren't laughable anymore, especially since the wolf-sints of the western mountains have joined forces with the most militant of the rabbit-sints behind the banner of their martyred "Liberator", the traitor-huum called Malavorra.

Within Beshquahoek's perfect geometry, in the brooder houses where women sing at dawn, in the Tagabant camps, in the barracks where teenaged Volunteer oil their cudgels, and in the Scribal towers and temples where old folk parse the Book of Heliohdamus seeking justifications, or explanations, for the latest crackdown; everywhere the same question hovers unspoken: How long can this hold?

The Promise and the Price

If you ask most ordinary Fatuniks whether they support the Dominion, most will say yes without any hesitation. They mean it, too. For the hum Fatuniks, the security is real. The order, the stability is real. The structure provides genuine comfort to people whose temples are full of walls naming those who died in the Great Wars and in the Troubles, and who can remember times when starvation was the expected outcome of bad weather.

The promise of a better tomorrow that the Noonday Scribes preach isn't entirely hollow. Life is getting better for many Fatunik hum: more food, better roads, reduced conflict with neighboring provinces. The revanchist rhetoric about "restoring" the Dominion's ancient boundaries in the southern lands might be ridiculous propaganda, but the pride it sparks is authentic. We were great once. We can be great again. We're not like those chaotic Kahila with their star-worship and criminal lifestyles or the disgusting Settans with their animal-mixing. We're not like those violent Riders with their endless feuds. Or the dastardly Eelani, who openly flaunt Fatune's warnings. Nor the Outer Landers, with their fake praise for a fake Fatune. We keep the true light burning.

A baker in Heliohlan, a middle-aged woman named Preshta, puts it plainly while kneading root dough in the hour before dawn. "My daughter is learning letters at the brood house. My mother never did. My broodkin will have a trade, or maybe join the Eibar Tagabant. They will have a good life, with enough food. Is the New Authority harsh sometimes? Yes. Do I agree with everything the Noonday Scribes teach? Of course I do. Look around. Look at what we've built with their guidance. Order from chaos. Light from darkness. That's worth protecting."

The dough yields under her hands. Outside, the morning bells begin to ring. Soon the brooder houses will start their songs. The Watchers will change shifts. Vendors will arrange their stalls in prescribed arcs. The Temple spire will catch first light.

Here comes Fatune.

But in the prison cells at Beet, in the rabbit-servants' rest-hall where Tesh and Alysh lie awake thinking about the warren-mates they haven't seen in many turns, in the whispered conversations on the docks of Pavanoa, in the hearts of a mixt woman from Barból who sells her herbs below value just to escape the city's weight, there are new songs brewing. Quieter. Dangerous. And growing louder.

The Fatunik Dominion stands at a threshold it doesn't fully recognize.

Transformation is coming, whether the New Authority wills it or not. The question isn't whether change will arrive. The question is what form it will take, what violence it will require, what it will cost the folk of the Dominion, faithful and heretic, huum and sint alike, who've built their lives inside the undulating walls of Beshquahoek and in the provinces who look to the Center for guidance and protection.

Fatune rises every day, predictable and inevitable. What Fatune illuminates, though, depends on who's watching and what they're willing to see.

The Gleaming Capital

The walls came first.

Not the foundations, not the plaza, not the Shining Temple that dominates the skyline. The double walls. Tonedor Rumpet understood something fundamental about power; it must be seen from a distance before it can be felt up close. So in the first year after the Beshquo Reforms, when the site was still just windswept grassland Tablunque province where an old spa village was located, thousands of conscripts arrived with quarried stone and the Grand Tagabant's vision, made real by a team of expert engineers and architects from Byenung town.

They built in curves. Undulating lines that flow like frozen water, rising and falling in waves thirty feet high at their peak. No straight sections, no right angles. The mathematical precision required to execute this design pushed Fatunik engineering to its limits. Master builders from Khaliro argued it was impossible. Scribes from Juuj declared it impractical. Rumpet insisted, and he paid the Runik experts well to make it work, and the walls rose.

Stand outside Beshquahoek at dawn and watch what happens when Fatune touches those curves. The light doesn't just strike stone. It flows along the undulations like liquid gold, creating the illusion that the walls themselves move, breathe, live. This is intentional. This is theology rendered in limestone and mortar. The Inextinguishable made manifest.

A stonemason named Gretch worked on the northern section during the third year of construction. His hands bear the scars: fingers broken and badly set, palms crosshatched with white lines where chisels slipped. He's forty now, living in the eastern workers' quarter with his work team. When visitors ask about the walls, he tells them about the mathematics. The survey chains and plumb lines. The endless arguments between the master builders about weight distribution and stress points.

What he doesn't tell them: how many died. Falls, mostly. Cave-ins at the quarries. One entire section of the southern wall collapsed during a storm, burying seventeen workers under tons of stone. The bodies were never fully recovered. They're still there, incorporated into the rebuilt section. Gretch knows which stones, could point them out if asked. He never volunteers the information.

The walls took three years. The city within took seven more.

The Geometry of Faith

From above, if you could achieve such a perspective, Beshquahoek's layout resembles the diagrams in the old Juuj scrolls about cosmic order. The great plaza sits at the center, a perfect circle paved in white stone imported from quarries throughout the central range. From this hub, the streets radiate outward in arcs, not the straight spokes you'd find in lesser towns but curved lines that echo the walls' undulations.

The effect is disorienting at first. New arrivals from the provinces wander lost for days, unable to develop the mental maps that work in normal cities where streets intersect at predictable angles. The faithful claim this is precisely the point. The layout teaches humility. You

cannot master Beshquahoek through logic alone. You must internalize it, let it become part of your body's knowledge, accept its reality rather than imposing your expectations upon it.

The plaza itself measures two hundred paces across. At noon during summer's height, standing at the exact center, Fatune strikes without shadow. The Noonday Scribes demonstrate this annually during the Culmination ceremonies at the start of the season of the Gleaming, positioning volunteers on marked spots while the High Watchers confirm the shadow's absence. It's spectacular theater. The crowd gasps every year as if witnessing miracle rather than applied geometry.

The Temple rises from the plaza's northern edge. Its spire reaches almost 45 meters, making it the tallest structure in the Saskan Lands, if one ignores the Mistral Tower, which is easy to do. The base is octagonal, representing the eight moons whose darkness the Inextinguishable overcomes. The walls taper as they rise, and the entire structure tilts infinitesimally toward the south, aligning with Fatune's winter nadir. You can't see the tilt from ground level but it is there.

Inside, the Temple's main hall can hold three thousand faithful for morning and evening devotions. The acoustics are extraordinary. A whisper at the eastern altar carries clearly to the western galleries. The Scribes use this for effect during services, their voices seeming to come from everywhere and nowhere, surrounding the congregation in sound.

The floor is inlaid with concentric circles in alternating white and black stone. The pattern draws the eye toward the central altar where a sacred flame burns day and night, tended by the speechless, tongues-removed order of the Velkharim. In ancient times, they remained silent by choice. The New Authority literalized their vocation. They feed the flame with purified oil rendered from animal fat, a practice that troubles some of the more vegetable-minded faithful but which the Scribes defend as symbolic consumption of darkness by light.

The Quarters and Their Character

The city divides into six major quarters, each with its own flavor and function. The administrative quarter lies northwest of the plaza, housing the Grand Tagabant's residence, the High Council chambers, the Scribal archives. The buildings here are severe, built from dark stone, designed to impress rather than welcome. Wide steps lead to heavy doors. Guards stand at intervals, no young Volunteers here. These are veteran Beshquo Tagabant, chosen for reliability and known for a certain deadness in the eyes.

The eastern quarter houses the workers, craftsmen, servants who keep Beshquahoek functioning. The streets narrow here, the buildings crowd together, four and five stories tall with washing hung between windows. The smell shifts from the plaza's incense and oil to something earthier: cooking fires, waste in the cesspits, the yeasty ferment from the bakeries that supply the city's bread. The rabbit-sint quarters are walled off from those of the hum workers.

Gretch the mason lives on Curver Street, named for the specialized craftsmen who shaped the wall stones. His building leans slightly, settling unevenly on foundations rushed during construction. Every few years someone reports it to the municipal Watchers. Every few years an inspector comes, measures, declares it acceptable. The building keeps leaning.

His neighbor, a woman named Salla who works in a brooder house, complains about the morning bells. They wake her before she's ready, she says, before her body wants to rise. But she says this quietly, only after checking that no Volunteers are listening. Complaining about the bells edges toward heresy. Not actionable heresy. Not yet. But the kind of thing that gets noted, remembered, referenced later if other questions arise. Nobody wants a visit from the Candle Makers. A barely-disguised branch of the Meyajo Tagabant, everybody knows they aren't coming to bring actual candles.

The southern quarter belongs to the military. Barracks for the Tagabant, training grounds, armories, and holding cells for prisoners

awaiting Testing or transport to Beet. You can hear it from blocks away: the rhythmic chanting of drilling units, the clash of practice weapons, the occasional scream from the cells below the main barracks.

A young recruit serves in the southern quarter's third company. He's nineteen, been in service fourteen months, earned his blade after his second Testing. The weapon hangs at his belt now, a short sword with the Fatunik sun-mark stamped in the cross guard. He oils it every evening, practices the forms his sergeant teaches, dreams of the day he'll make full Tagabant.

What keeps him awake some nights is the memory of his first Testing. They'd raided a suspected heretic gathering in one of the eastern quarter's basement taverns. Found twelve hum, mostly older folks, studying what turned out to be fire-cult song lyrics smuggled in from Mobalbesq. The raid went smoothly. No resistance. But afterward, in the cells, he had drawn guard duty. One of the prisoners, a hum woman maybe sixty years old, asked him why. Why were fire-cult songs praising Fatune's light reborn on the ground considered heresy? Why did learning them threaten anything? Didn't they understand that fire is Fatune's gift?

He'd quoted the official doctrine: the fire-cults are mistaken. They denigrate the power of Fatune's light, claiming that anybody can control it. She'd nodded, thanked him for explaining, said nothing more. They burned her three days later. The young guard wasn't on execution duty but he attended the ceremony in the plaza, watched her die with what looked like dignity.

He still can't explain why the memory bothers him. The woman was a heretic. The doctrine is clear. But some nights he lies in his barracks bunk and remembers her question, remembers the reasonable tone of her voice, and sleep comes hard.

The Temple Quarter and the Velkharim

The Temple quarter occupies the northern section, spreading from the

great plaza. Here the streets are widest, the buildings most ornate. The High Council of the Watchers maintain residences here, as do the senior Noonday Scribes and the wealthiest guild masters who fund the Authority's operations.

The Velkharim live in a compound adjacent to the Temple itself. They're not quite monks and not quite servants. Their order predates the Beshquo Reforms by many centuries, originating in the early days of Juuj when the first Watchers needed attendants who wouldn't gossip or betray confidences as the Elders debated the fine points of the Book and began to develop their commentaries. The vow of silence was literal and permanent. But now their tongues are cut out during initiation to ensure no leaks.

Tull, who tends the sacred flame on the night shifts, has been silent for thirty-two turns. Communication occurs through a complex sign language the Velkharim teach each other, and through writing when necessary. Tull's hands move with particular grace when signing, compensating perhaps for a surrendered voice.

Tull knows things the speaking world doesn't. Present when High Watchers meet in the Temple's private chambers, the order sees who visits whom in the hours before dawn. They read the messages that arrive by courier from the provincial centers. The Velkharim are treated as furniture, reliable and unobtrusive. This makes them the best-informed people in Beshquahoek.

Velkha Tull believes in the Inextinguishable and in the promise of tomorrow with a faith that is genuine, uncomplicated by politics and power games. Tending the flame gives purpose. The silence brings peace. For Tull, the speaking world is pitied for its noise, its constant need to fill emptiness with words that mean less than people imagine.

But the Velkharim also notice things. The increasing frequency of Council meetings. The tension in the Grand Tagabant's posture during morning devotions. The way certain Scribes avoid eye contact with certain others. Something is building. A pressure is mounting beneath

the New Authority's gleaming surface.

Tull says nothing. They tend the flame, sweep the Temple floors, change the oil in the ceremonial lamps. When the breaking comes, whatever form it takes, the Velkharim will still be there. Silent. Watching. Remembering.

The Western Markets

The western quarter hosts Beshquahoek's main markets, sprawling affairs that draw traders from across the Dominion and beyond. The layout bends the city's curved geometry toward function. The stalls arrange in concentric rings, outer rings for common goods and traveling vendors, inner rings for specialties and luxuries.

The noise here drowns out the Temple bells. Vendors hawk their wares in voices honed to carry over crowd noise. Buyers haggle in a dozen dialects. Non-sentient animals bleat and low from the livestock pens. Somewhere a street musician plays an old Qurol tune on a battered horn, the melody threading through the ordered chaos.

The Day Watch patrols in pairs, checking permits, inspecting goods for prohibited items. They're looking for astronomical charts, forbidden texts, herbs that suggest Kahila influence, any sign that traders are bringing contamination into the city. Most of the Watch pairs are reasonable. They understand the markets are where money flows, and money funds the Authority. They're not like the young Volunteers. They know that overzealous enforcement strangles commerce.

But some of the Dorq Tagabant and the Volunteers take market patrol as opportunity for petty tyranny. They confiscate goods arbitrarily, demand bribes, hassle vendors who can't produce documentation immediately. The market supervisor, an old Tagabant veteran named Qesh who lost his sword-arm fighting barbarians on the northern frontier, does his best to restrain the worst offenders. Mostly he succeeds. Sometimes he doesn't.

A mixt woman named from Barból sells medicinal herbs from a stall

in the outer ring. She makes the journey to Beshquahoek four times a year. Her stamps look legitimate, purchased at considerable expense from a corrupt clerk in Heliohlan. The herbs themselves are legal. They treat common ailments: fever, cough, digestive trouble. Nothing magical, nothing that suggests dangerous knowledge. And much more effective than locally-grown versions. When people ask in an whisper about the Forghan Weed, she just shrugs.

She feels the weight of eyes every moment she's in the city. The casual contempt in how many buyers examine her face, looking for signs of animal heritage, reshaped features, corruption. The way the Watchers linger near her stall, not threatening but present, a reminder that her permission to be here is temporary and revocable. The occasional degrading encounter with a Volunteer.

She sells quickly, prices low, eager to leave. Made twenty aybets last trip. Enough to feed her farm team back home for two months. Enough to make the anxiety worth swallowing.

The Night Markets

Beshquahoek transforms after dark. The curved streets that seemed disorienting in daylight become more dangerous. The Night Watch patrols with shuttered lanterns, revealing their positions only when choosing to. Between their sweeps, the streets other economies emerge.

Prostitution is technically illegal under Fatunik law, except in Qurol town, where it is a venerable institution, regulated and protected. The official position is that all sexual activity should occur only within sanctioned brooder pairings for the purpose of insemination, carefully monitored to maintain bloodline purity and population control. In practice, even in the heart of the Fatunik Dominion, desire is impossible to contain. All manner of dalliances and prostitution thrive. The Night Watch knows where the night-time clubs and brothels operate. For the most part, they extract their tribute and look away.

A woman named Ofdob runs three night houses in the eastern quarter. Two are for casual hook-ups and the third takes care of paying clients. She pays the Night Watch, pays the local Dorq Tagabant commander, pays the municipal officials who could shut her down with a word and she pays a network of broodkins to stay a step ahead of Volunteers who explore her district at night hunting for heretics. What she offers isn't just sex but privacy, discretion, a place where the weight of Fatunik propriety lifts for an hour or two.

Her clients include locals who can't acknowledge their desires publicly, merchants traveling without families, and even an occasional Scribe or official whose ascetic vows bend considerably in darkness. She keeps records, hidden carefully behind bricks in the wall, insurance against the day someone decides her tribute isn't sufficient.

Night markets operate in parallel to the sanctioned daytime trade. Prohibited goods change hands: star charts from Mobalbesq and Terpinol, exotic trinkets from the Kahila woods, rare silks from Settarrune, Rider and Mobali songs transcribed on stolen paper, rare herbs whose properties go way beyond treating coughs. The prices are high, the risks higher, but demand persists. And within the night trade, an even more occulted, if entirely mundane trade in vegetables goes on around the walls of the rabbit-sint workers quarter, where hum who either secretly sympathetic or see an opportunity for high returns peddle food to the always-hungry rabbits.

An old hum man named Turrik brokers information. He knows who needs what, who has what, who can be trusted and who can't. He takes his percentage and asks no questions about why someone wants, say, a detailed map of the Dominion's southern borders or a treatise on the phases of the moons, or canvas bag full of leafy vegetables. He's survived forty years in the night trade by developing an acute sense of when the Authority's attention is shifting, when it's time to lie low, when it's safe to operate.

Lately his instincts say danger. Too many arrests. Too many raids. The New Authority is tightening its grip, trying to squeeze order from

chaos through pure force. Turrik has seen this before. It never ends well. And the current environment feels worse than previously. He's considering retirement, maybe moving to Pavanarune province where things are looser. Maybe even to Ríkila town, right on the border with Mobalbesq. But he's old, and change is hard, and one more season probably won't hurt.

The Gleaming and the Rot

There's a particular quality to Beshquahoek's light. The white stone of the plaza reflects Fatune's rays with unusual intensity, creating a brightness that can hurt the eyes. The Temple spire catches and concentrates light, throwing it back skyward in visible shafts. The undulating walls create complex shadow patterns that shift throughout the day.

The faithful interpret this as divine blessing, proof that Fatune smiles on the city that Rumpet built. The Runik architects know it's deliberate design, the calculated result of material choices and structural angles. They still discuss the mathematics, and how they might be further modified, during sessions at the Night Hall. Both things can be true simultaneously.

But there's rot beneath the gleam. Despite the best efforts of Byenung's finest engineers, the rushed construction demanded by the Grand Tagabant left weaknesses in Temple's foundations, drainage systems that work poorly so that the moat between the double walls sometimes floods, buildings that settle unevenly like Gretch's leaning home. The sewers -- an innovation in urban design -- back up during heavy rains, flooding the eastern quarter's lower streets with waste. The city was built for sixty thousand people. Eighty thousand live here now, with more arriving weekly.

The brooder houses can't keep up with demand for communal child-rearing. Unofficial arrangements proliferate. Children are secretly raised in extended families. The careful monitoring systems break down through sheer volume. The Watchers note this and report it

upward. The High Council debates solutions. Nothing changes.

The prisons overflow. The cells beneath the southern barracks were built for maybe two hundred prisoners. Four hundred are crammed in there now, awaiting Testing, transport, trial, or simply forgotten in the administrative muddle. Disease spreads. Guards develop coughs they can't shake. Prisoners die, their bodies removed at night, tossed into a charnel house outside the walls without so much as a prayer. The flames burn day and night.

A young Volunteer is being Tested with guard duty at the prison entrance twice a week. The smell seeps up from below: unwashed bodies, infected wounds, fear that has its own particular odor. He's learned to breathe through his mouth. Learned not to listen too carefully to the sounds that echo from the depths. Learned to see the prisoners as abstract threats to good order rather than as creatures in the light of Fatune.

This learning troubles him. He recognizes what he's becoming, what the service requires him to become. Sometimes he thinks about deserting, heading east to Ingar or Pavanarune or beyond. But where would he go? What would he be without the structure that a life with the Tagabant would provide? Could he survive in the Outer Lands, living alongside of sints?

The Grand Tagabant's Vision

Tonedor Rumpet rarely appears in public anymore. He's ninety-three, frail in body if not in will. His presence saturates Beshquahoek in ways that don't require physical manifestation. The city is his vision rendered in stone and blood, his answer to the question of what the Dominion could become if purified of compromise and doubt.

He lives in the administrative quarter's central fortress, a building within a building, walls within walls. The Velkharim attend him. The High Watchers consult him. Twice a year -- at the start of summer and during the Gleaming -- he appears on the balcony of the Shining Temple of Fatune during major ceremonies, raises his hand in

blessing, and the crowd roars its approval.

What they're approving: the security he's delivered, the end to the Kahila troubles, the gleaming capital that proves Fatunik superiority. What they're not seeing is the cost of that security, the bodies buried in Beet, the steady stream of refugees and deserters fleeing through occupied territories and porous borders, the rot spreading beneath the white stone plaza.

Or maybe they see it and don't care. Maybe the bargain seems fair. Order in exchange for cruelty, security in exchange for oppression. Maybe Gretch the mason, lying in his leaning house, listening to co-workers breathe in the darkness, thinks the price is worth paying. Maybe Salla the brooder house worker, separated from her own children, thinks the same.

The walls undulate in the moonlight, creating shadows that move like living things. The sacred flame burns in the Temple, tended by the Velkharim who know more than they can say. In the prison cells, people scream. In the night markets, forbidden fruit, hidden knowledge and unsanctioned embraces are exchanged. In the High Council chambers, decisions get made that will shape the next decade, the next century, the transformation that's coming whether anyone wills it or not.

Beshquahoek gleams. The rot spreads. Fatune rises every morning over the undulating walls, striking them with light that looks like white liquid gold, like divine blessing, like hope.

Like all things hum-made, the city is all of these at once: beautiful and terrible, ordered and jumbled, eternal and already crumbling. The Gleaming Capital. The All-Seeing Eye of Fatune. The heart of the Dominion.

It will not last forever. Nothing does. But for now, in this moment, it stands. The bells ring. The faithful happily sing "here comes Fatune".

The Authority and the Watch

The boy was twelve when they came for him. Not arrested, nothing like that. His name is Vosh. He is of the age when a broodkin leaves the brooder house to seek a useful trade. They told him he was lucky. He'd been selected. The Day Watcher who delivers the news to his brood mother speaks in formal cadences, reading from a prepared text. This broodkin has demonstrated the qualities necessary for service. He will report to a Beshquo training compound on the first day of next month. This is a great honor for your house.

The brood-mother nods, thanks the Watcher, closes the door. Alone with Vosh, she allows herself one moment of grief before smoothing it from her face. "You'll make us proud," she tells him, and means it, and hates that she means it.

This is how the Authority sustains itself. Not primarily through force, though force is always available. Through recruitment, integration, the steady absorption of each generation into the machinery of control. Vosh will spend the next six years learning to watch, to report, to see deviation as threat. He'll emerge at eighteen either as a full Watcher or, if he proves insufficiently observant, assigned to some other function within the system. Either way, he'll be theirs in every way. And he will count himself lucky.

The morning he leaves, his brood-mother packs his few belongings in a canvas sack. She includes a scarf she knitted, though he'll never be allowed to wear it. Just something to remember her by, she thinks but doesn't say. Vosh shoulders the sack and walks the curved streets to the compound without looking back. He's learned already that looking back is a form of doubt, and doubt is the enemy of good order.

The Architecture of Observation

The Watch isn't a single organization. It's a collection of overlapping authorities, each with its own jurisdiction and traditions, all theoretically coordinated through the High Council but in practice

often working at cross-purposes. The Day Watch monitors public behavior, enforces municipal regulations, checks documentation at markets and gates. The Night Watch operates in darkness, tracking movement through empty streets, raiding suspected heretic gatherings, maintaining the fiction that nighttime is dangerous without their protection.

The Riverwaq patrols the Pavan River and its tributaries, inspecting cargo on commercial vessels, monitoring for unauthorized travelers, extracting tolls that fund their operations. They're the smallest branch, the most easy-going, the most likely to accept bribes and look the other way for minor infringements. They're also the most practical and the most well-liked. They understand that total control of river traffic is impossible, so they settle for profitable compromise. And they sing. They sing loud, proud and often. Everyone knows when the Riverwaq patrol boat is approaching, arriving or leaving. They have a song for every occasion.

There are numerous specialized units. The Archive Watchers monitor the Scribal libraries, tracking who reads what, noting patterns that might suggest heretical inquiry. The Market Watchers who focus on commercial spaces, ensuring no prohibited goods enter circulation. The Border Watch are stationed next to Tagabant frontier guards at provincial boundaries, checking papers, interrogating travelers about their purposes and loyalties.

A Watcher named Gubadobrof has served in the Day Watch for twenty-three turns, patrolling the eastern quarter of Beshquahoeck, the workers' districts, walking the same streets for two decades. Gubadobrof knows every shopkeeper, every household, every regular pattern of movement. When something deviates from pattern, he notices.

Old Turrik the information broker, for instance. Gubadobrof has known for years what Turrik does, how he facilitates the night market economy, even filed reports mentioning Turrik's activities. But the reports go into the vast administrative void of the Watch bureaucracy, evaluated by senior Watchers who decide that Turrik's network

provides more value as a monitored intelligence source than as a target for suppression.

This is the assumption, anyway. No one ever said to leave Turrik alone. Gubadobrof simply notices that nothing happens after reporting on Turrik's movements. Bureaucratic silence gets interpreted as tacit approval. Gubadobrof watches, notes, files reports, and Turrik continues operating.

The relationship between them has developed an odd quality over the years. They nod to each other on the street. Exchange pleasantries about the weather. Gubadobrof knows that Turrik knows that Gubadobrof knows. They even ran into each other once, somewhat awkwardly, one night at one of the less well-known night houses. It's a dance of mutual understanding, each playing their role in a system that neither fully controls.

The Fist of the Authority

Where the Watch observes, the Tagabant acts. The military units are trained for combat and for policing. They are increasingly used for internal enforcement as external threats diminish and internal ones proliferate. Each major province maintains its own Tagabant cohort, and the rivalries between units sometimes mirror the tensions between regions.

There are also larger regiments drawn from multiple areas and reporting directly to the High Council of the New Authority in Beshqauhoek. The fabled Eibar Tagabant, named for the iconic southeastern province where the Dominion was born, are drawn from the most promising candidates in all parts of the Dominion. They pride themselves on discipline. Their training is brutal, their standards high and their reputation unassailable. An Eibar recruit spends three years in preliminary service before earning the right to carry a blade. They drill in all weather, sleep in unheated barracks even during winter, and subsist on minimal rations. The theory is that hardship breeds reliability. Mostly it works. Sometimes it produces fanatics.

Commander Vresh leads the third Eibar cohort, stationed in Beshquahoek's southern quarter. He's fifty-eight, been in service since sixteen, climbed through ranks by being exactly what the Authority needed at each moment. As a young soldier he fought in skirmishes against the Ilyushan, enforced a kind of order in parts of Arq when lizard-sints from Komikol tried to reclaim their ancient lands, has patrolled through rebel-held part of the Kahila lands and fought in numerous large-scale battles on the northern frontier. As a mid-rank officer he helped implement the Beshquo Reforms, recruiting and training the first wave of troops for the New Authority. Now, as a senior commander, he wrestles with administrative duties he finds tedious and with philosophical questions he'd prefer to ignore.

His cohort includes three hundred soldiers. They rotate through various duties: garrison service in the occupied territories, escort for high-value military shipments, security for major ceremonies, suppression of civil disturbances. But most of the work is boring. Long hours standing guard. Longer hours training new recruits. Occasional bursts of violence that end quickly once the Tagabant deploy in force.

Vresh remembers when the work felt purposeful. The battles against the northern barbarians and the Ilyushan monsters had clear enemies, clear objectives. Now everything is ambiguous. The threats are more internal, ideological, impossible to address through military force alone. You can't defeat doubt with a sword. But the New Authority keeps trying, and Vresh keeps following orders, and three hundred soldiers keep drilling in the southern quarter.

One of those soldiers, a hum woman named Petsha, joined the Eibar Tagabant four years ago. She's from a farming family in Norgyte, volunteered for service to escape the monotony of the northern plains and fought her way through Testing and training to prove that a woman was equally capable to the men. There is no law that says women can't serve in the Tagabant, but it is rare. They offer her structure, purpose, and the promise of something larger than herself.

What it delivered was routine punctuated by horror. Most days she

cleans equipment, drills formations, stands guard at checkpoints where nothing happens. Once a month, maybe, her cohort is deployed for active operations. Raids on suspected heretic gatherings. Assaults on villages suspected of harboring the Untamed. Arrests of prohibited persons. She's learned to execute these duties without thinking too carefully about what they mean.

Last month her squad raided a basement gathering in the eastern quarter. Seventeen people arrested, mostly elderly, studying what turned out to be historical texts written in Sogomsh about Ma Eshuna's early charitable work with the rabbit-sint communities. Not explicitly heretical, but close enough. The arrests were peaceful. No resistance. The prisoners went quietly into their holding cells beneath the barracks.

Petsha stood guard during their interrogation. Listened to them explain that they were simply curious, simply interested in understanding more about their rabbit-sint neighbors. The interrogator, a specialist from the Meyajo Tagabant, explained patiently that such curiosity was dangerous, that it distracted from proper focus on Fatune's light, that Sogomsh was an animalistic language, that historical knowledge without Scribal supervision leads to bad thinking.

Most of the prisoners recanted. They signed documents admitting error and were released after three days, with warnings entered into their permanent records. Two refused to recant. They were transported to Beet. Petsha doesn't know what happened to them after that. She doesn't want to know.

She lies in her barracks bunk some nights and tries to square the person she wanted to be with the person the service has made her into. The calculation doesn't balance. But she signed a ten-year commitment, and desertion carries the death penalty, and where would she go anyway? They say that in the Runes of Bye the common folk speak both Eibar and Sogomsh, sometimes even Arql, and that rabbit-sints attend meetings in the Night Hall just like the hum, as if the languages were all equally good and all sentients were

equal in the light of Fatune.

So she drills, she guards, she executes her duties, and the dissonance grows.

The Khaliro Exception

Not all Tagabant units maintain Eibar standards. The Khaliro Tagabant, stationed at the great fortress in Khālo town that guards the Pavan's largest and most famous bridge, have developed a reputation for the kind of extreme pragmatism that turns profiteering into a profession. They control one of the most lucrative checkpoint in the Dominion, the main checkpoint between north and south of the Pavan. Every trader crossing the river pays a toll. Every shipment is inspected. The opportunities for supplemental income are enormous.

Commander Besht runs the Khaliro operation with the efficiency of a master guildler. Official tolls are collected and properly recorded. Unofficial tolls, paid in exchange for expedited processing or reduced inspection scrutiny, go into a separate fund that pays bonuses to his troops and his allies and maintains his own comfortable lifestyle.

The High Council of the New Authority knows about this. Periodic investigations are launched, always announced in advance, always producing carefully sanitized findings. The reality is that Khaliro's location makes it too valuable to disrupt and the Khālo brigade of the Tagabant provides an annual offering directly to the Grand Tagabant. Replacing Besht would create a power vacuum, possibly even triggering conflict with the Bordali on the western border of Khaliro province, whose trade relations with the town are based on centuries of formal and informal agreements. Better a corrupt but functional checkpoint than a contested one.

Besht himself sees no contradiction between his practices and his loyalty to the Beshquahoek. He enforces Fatunik law scrupulously in matters of heresy, prohibited persons, and ideological contamination. What he takes in trade fees strikes him as efficient taxation, a way of funding operations without draining the central treasury.

His soldiers, particularly the officers who share in the bounty, agree with this perspective. A young recruit named Temmoq earned more in his first year through a minor take in the toll-sharing than his father made in five turns working the hunting grounds of Sungyte. He sends money home, helps support his village team, sees himself as successful. When he checks papers at the crossing, he's courteous and professional, willing to overlook minor irregularities for appropriate consideration. He has made connections with folks from all over and even once spent an exciting evening at a Khālo night house with a Rider from Turno.

Was it sleeping with the enemy? Maybe. But he also learned some interesting things about how Rider-owned Inns operate around the Ring. Is it corruption? Yes, of a sort. But it's corruption that keeps the system functioning, that prevents the rigid enforcement of impossible standards, that creates space for the actual economy to operate. Temmoq doesn't think of it this way, for the most part. With occasional qualms, he thinks he's doing his job, helping his village, and serving the Dominion. All true. All compatible with a system that is slowly rotting from within.

The Young Believers

The newest and most zealous component of the enforcement apparatus reinvented by Tonedor Rumpet is the revived Fatunik Volunteers. The name is historical, referring to folks in centuries past who took up arms and pitched in during emergencies, then returned to farm work afterwards. Such old-style Volunteers still exist in the Outer Lands, where their Fatunik faith has little resemblance to what goes on inside the Dominion, where being a Volunteer now designates young recruits, aged fourteen to eighteen, who join before entering full Tagabant service if they demonstrate that they are qualified.

The Volunteers get minimal training, basic equipment, and maximum indoctrination. They're taught that the Dominion is under constant threat from heretics, animal-lovers, corrupted bloodlines, foreign ideas, animal-sints and invaders. They're shown the remains of

villages destroyed during the assault on the Kahila lands and told that only their vigilance prevents similar horror from returning. Their instructors don't bother to mention that the destroyed villages were home to Kahila, not Eibar folk.

Then they're given cudgels and sent into the streets.

A Volunteer named Ofdob joined at fifteen. He's seventeen now, having served long enough to earn a blade, and eager to prove himself worthy of full Tagabant status. He patrols the western market district of Beshqauhoek, checking permits, interrogating vendors about merchandise origins, giving hard stares at out-of-towners, looking for any sign of prohibited activity.

His sergeant, a veteran Beshquo Tagabant named Pell, tries to temper Ofdob's enthusiasm. "Watch for patterns," Pell tells him. "Don't harass every mixt vendor or foreign trader. Focus on actual threats." But defining actual threats requires a level of judgment Ofdob hasn't developed yet. Everything looks suspicious to him. Every deviation from expected behavior seems potentially like heresy.

Last week Ofdob detained a merchant from Brokily for selling silk scarves. The merchant explained they were warm in winter, useful for protecting the head during strong winds, and completely legal. Ofdob insisted on confiscating them anyway, filing a report, lecturing the merchant on the modesty of all Dominion subjects, how neither male nor female have any need to parade around like wild animals, and subjecting the merchant to three hours of interrogation, accusing her of being a Kahila rebel, before Pell intervened and sorted out the mess.

The merchant left angry, unlikely to return to Beshquahoek. The western market supervisor complained to Pell about lost trade revenue. Pell reprimanded Ofdob, explained the distinction between heretical immodesty and practical clothing and pointed out that most merchants arriving from the Brokily road are Settaronik, not Kahila. Ofdob nodded, said he understood, but remained convinced that the

merchant from Kahilabeq was probably hiding something.

This is the Volunteer problem. They're true believers in a system that requires cynical compromise to function. They take the devotion to Fatune seriously in ways that make them simultaneously essential and dangerous. The Fatunik Authority needs their energy, their willingness to enforce doctrine without doubt. But their lack of judgment creates constant friction with the actual mechanisms of governance.

The High Council of the New Authority

At the apex of this sprawling machinery sits the High Council of the New Authority, sometimes called the High Watchers. They are twelve senior officials who coordinate, theoretically at any rate, the various enforcement branches and who, along with the senior Scribes, advise the Grand Tagabant on matters of security and order. They meet in the administrative quarter of Beshquahoek, in a building adjacent to Rumpet's fortress, in chambers designed to intimidate.

The current council includes representatives from each major branch of Watchers, senior Tagabant commanders, including the Candle Makers, and several Scribal officials who provide ideological guidance. They're all hum men, all over fifty, all products of the system they now oversee. A few of the oldest ones served Authority since before the Beshquo Reforms, making the transition from the old Authority centered at Juuj to the new centralized power at Beshquahoek. But most of them were appointed or promoted since the Reforms.

Supreme Night Watcher Qonurk'lolhan, who chairs the council sessions, remembers when the Watches were small units of town-based criers concerned with making warnings about threats to public order. Now it's a vast bureaucracy drowning in its own reports, with filing systems that span entire buildings and administrative processes that slow decision-making to near-paralysis.

A typical council meeting involves reviewing hundreds of reports

from provincial Watch leaders, Tagabant commanders, border stations, and market supervisors. Most are routine: X number of permits checked, Y number of inspections conducted, Z number of arrests made. The sheer volume of information makes pattern recognition nearly impossible. Occasionally something significant emerges. A series of raids in the northern provinces revealed a suspected heretic network developing in Returner villages. Intelligence about Untamed activity near the border with the Kahilakol. Reports of large-scale Rider cavalry patrols between Moak and Norgldūn, near the northern border. Something very odd that somebody overheard a Beqawar say in Ríkila. These get attention, resources, action.

But the everyday functioning of the Watches, the Tagabant, the Volunteers, all of this happens largely without oversight. The machinery runs itself, powered by institutional momentum, individual initiative, and the accumulated weight of countless small decisions made by people like Gubadobrof, Vresh, Besht, and Ofdob.

Qonurk'lolhan understands this. He's been in administration long enough to recognize that top-down control is mostly illusion. The real power lies in the hands of mid-level functionaries, in the true believers who implement policy, interpret orders, decide what gets reported and what doesn't.

He's also noticed something troubling. Reports coming from the provinces reveal an increasing resistance to Authority directives. Not open rebellion, nothing so clear, nothing so daring. Just friction. Delayed implementation. Creative misunderstanding. The kind of passive resistance that's impossible to address through enforcement but that slowly erodes central power.

At the last council meeting, Qonurk'lolhan raised this concern. The other members nodded, agreed it was worrying, suggested increasing Watch presence in problematic provinces, maybe sending in more Meyajo spies. And before they turned to other matters, he caught their attention again, with a report that two Riders patrolling the Ring road near Qurol town had been heard making jokes in public about the

Grand Tagabant himself. Dead silence. No one mentioned the underlying issue. The New Authority's expanded reach has exceeded its capacity for control.

The Daily Mechanism

The system sustains itself through routine more than coercion. Most people never interact directly with the Watch beyond showing papers at checkpoints or answering questions during market inspections. Most hum who are natives of the Dominion are seldom bothered by the Volunteers. The Authority's presence is ambient, a background awareness that shapes behavior without requiring constant enforcement.

A baker named Surl rises before dawn, lights his ovens, begins the day's production. He's registered with the municipal authorities, pays his tithes, follows the regulations about grain and root usage and pricing. Once a month a Market Watcher inspects his operation, checks his records, ensures compliance. The inspection takes only three ways. Surl offers tea. The Watcher accepts. They discuss the weather, the quality of this year's harvests and hunts, nothing consequential.

This is governance as a background hum. Surl doesn't think of himself as oppressed or controlled. He has a business, a livelihood, a fixed place in the social order. The regulations are annoying but manageable. The taxes are high but not crushing. The alternative, chaos and uncertainty and war, seems much worse.

His apprentice, a young woman named Hurow'qin, sees things differently. She's nineteen, born long after the Beshquo Reforms, a product of the brooder system, has no real knowledge of the Kahila conflict or the instability that preceded Rumpet's rise. The Authority's restrictions feel somewhat arbitrary to her, unjustified by any real visible threat. Why does it matter if she reads texts from Terpinol? Why should the Watch care what she thinks about the moons? Why should she have to present herself in the same way that boys do, that everybody does except for the high officials? What is the point in

everybody looking the same?

Sometimes she asks Surl these questions. He tells her she's young, doesn't understand how quickly order can collapse into violence. She tells him he's old, doesn't understand that the Authority's stories are a con to keep the old men in power. They argue, reach no resolution, continue working together.

This generational divide runs through the Dominion. The older generation, who remember stories of real chaos in the recent past, accepts the Authority's bargain. The younger generation, raised in relative stability, questions why the bargain is necessary, what purpose is served by all the restrictions and surveillance. The Watchers monitor this tension, file reports, recommend increased education for youth, more funds for Volunteer training. But you can't force belief, only compliance. And compliance without belief is a fragile thing.

The Cracks in the Eye

Tull, the Velkhar who tends the sacred flame in the Temple, watches the members of the High Council of the New Fatunik Authority come and go from their chambers. He sees the exhaustion in their movements, the way they walk slower than they used to, the way their conversations have shifted from confident directives to worried consultations.

The Authority is overextended. Too many Watcher branches with overlapping jurisdictions. Too many Tagabant units with conflicting loyalties and old equipment. Too many Volunteers acting with insufficient judgment. Too many reports drowning the decision-makers in noise.

The machine still functions, but it's straining against its own weight. Each arrest creates resentment among the arrested person's network. Each toll extracted at the Khālo crossing feeds the perception of corruption. Each zealous Volunteer harassing a vendor in the markets of the Dominion towns drives trade elsewhere. Each heretic burned at

the Gleaming creates a martyr's memory that spreads through whispered conversations. And silly as it sounds, now the rabbits are revolting. And this time they are drawing blood.

Commander Vresh sees this from the military side. His soldiers drill and guard and raid, but he can feel their morale slowly deteriorating. They joined to defend the Dominion against external threats. Instead they're arresting old people for reading books, confiscating herbs from mixt vendors, standing guard at prison cells that overflow with people whose crimes are theoretical, and harassing old rabbit-sints. High Watcher Qonurk'lolhan sees it from the administrative side. The reports pile higher. The problems multiply faster than solutions can be implemented. The Grand Tagabant, aging and increasingly isolated in his fortress, issues directives that sound increasingly harsh and disconnected from actual conditions.

Even young Ofdob the Volunteer, still zealous in his belief, notices moments that don't fit the narrative. The merchant he harassed was just trying to make a living. The old people his squad arrested for studying moon charts weren't plotting rebellion, just curious about the skies. The vendors he intimidates are scared, not dangerous. These observations don't shake Ofdob's faith. Not yet. But they accumulate, small weights on a scale that might eventually tip. The Authority depends on people like Ofdob believing without questioning. When the questioning starts, when the observations pile too high to ignore, the machine will falter.

The twelve-year-old boy newly recruit into the Watch won't see the cracks right away. He's too young, too new, too thoroughly inducted into the system, too enthused about the praise he is receiving. But he might live long enough to help build whatever comes after. If he survives. If the transformation, when it comes, allows for survivors.

Fatune rises over Beshquahoek. The Watch changes shifts. The Tagabant drill in their compounds. Eager Volunteers patrol the markets hunting for heresy. The High Council convenes to review reports. The machine grinds forward, powerful and fragile, ordered and chaotic, sustained by routine and corroded by its own

contradictions.

If the All-Seeing Eye of Fatune blinks, in that moment of darkness, anything becomes possible.

Two Faces of Faith

The Organic Tower at Qurol defies every principle of rational architecture. It rises from the town's center like a crazy plant, bulging here, narrowing there, sprouting additions that seem to have no structural justification. Five hundred years of modifications, expansions, repairs, and pure whimsy have created something that looks less built than grown. A thick, tall balcony juts out from around the fourth level at an angle that makes engineers from Byenung shake their heads. The eighth floor is wider than the seventh. The top, some thirty meters up, hosts what locals call the Crow's Nest, a hooded circular platform where Town Watchers are supposed to maintain surveillance over the countryside, but mostly just get drunk and enjoy the view, all the way to Mount Eelan.

So many people over so many centuries have remarked on its resemblance to a big fat boner that once you see it, you can't un-see it. Replicas of the Tower are the number one selling trinket for visitors to the Qurol Bazaar.

No one remembers who started building it or why. The current best story about it involves a wealthy merchant meeting up with a Bordali architect who had peculiar ideas about load-bearing walls, and how they worked together to import several barrels of wine from Low Weir, of all places. The story, like the town itself, makes little sense but always makes its listeners loosen up and laugh. What matters is that the Organic Tower still stands, as it has stood through storms and

earthquakes and wars and and three major fires, and it still shows no signs of falling despite looking like it *should* collapse at any moment.

This is Qurol in microcosm. It shouldn't work, but it does anyway. And it doesn't care what you think about that.

Four hundred kilometers south, deep in the Borda Woods where the neatly-organized canopy of trees blocks Fatune's light for hours each day, the town of Heliohlan maintains a very different relationship with architectural. There, every building aligns on a grid. Streets intersect at right angles. The temple sits precisely at the town's geometric center, its spire pointing towards true north. When the Borda Tagabant drills in the central square, their formations are so exact you could measure them with survey chains.

Order is imposed on the Woods. Light is carved from the darkness because, as the Grand Tagabant has instructed, this is what the faithful do.

The Riverwaq Festival

Summer in Qurol means the river stage goes up. It takes a week to assemble. Massive wooden platforms are anchored to pilings driven deep into the riverbed, extending fifty meters from the eastern bank of the river. Smaller platforms float on barges, creating a constellation of performance spaces that bob and shift with the current. By the time the Riverwaq Festival begins, half the province has arrived, along with traders and off-duty soldiers from the Rider Provinces, musicians and travellers from the Settan towns and from all around the Ring. Even the occasional Eelani come down from their mountain enclaves to participate in the fun.

The noise is considerable. Three days and nights of music, dancing, theatrical performances, poetry competitions, and the signature Riverwaq water shows, where performers execute elaborate routines

while balanced on floating platforms or submerged in the river itself. The crowds pack the riverside, filling every available space, overflowing into temporary camps that sprawl across the fields north of town. And in Qurol town the night houses are not a secret. On the contrary, they are the town's main business.

Last year's festival drew over thirty thousand. The all-night inns and dance halls and brothels worked triple shifts, charging quadruple rates. Food vendors sold out of everything by the second day and sent fast caravans to Turno, Eelan and Bordakól for emergency resupply. The Watchers in Qurol never enforce the standard Fatunik curfew and settle instead for working to prevent actual murders, mostly successfully. For all its uproar, Qurol is pretty safe.

A young performer named Chelko, a nineteen turns-old Riverwaq singer with a voice that can shatter wine glasses or seduce stone, remembers his first Riverwaq Festival performance three years ago. He'd joined the Riverwaq from a rural village in Rutonijal, hoping to make a name for himself in town of Rutónik. His skilled voice was recognized right away as a major asset for the local regiment's choir. The sheer scale of the first Riverwaq Festival in Qurol town overwhelmed him. The main stage alone held two hundred people. The floating platforms required perfect balance and absolute confidence. One misstep meant a cold swim in the Pavan, which here, so close to the mountains, means you'll freeze your butt if you fall in.

He performed a traditional Rutonij hymn, one of the old style Fatune greeting songs, but arranged it with harmonics he'd invented herself, layered with rhythms borrowed from the Rider marching tunes that he loved. The crowd loved it. An agent from a so-called Bard's Guild offered him a contract to travel with them before he'd finished bowing. He declined; the officers had warned him about scams like that. Three years later he was a regular at the festival, receiving significant rewards from the local inn-keepers and impresarios, and is thinking about buying property in one of Qurol's nicer districts if he gets promoted and can be reassigned to Qurol.

This is how Qurol works. Talent finds opportunity. Innovation gets

rewarded. The old forms get twisted into new shapes, and if it works, and folks are happy and making a profit, nobody cares that you bent, maybe even broke, the rules as long as you don't actively mock the system. What happens in Qurol stays in Qurol, they say.

The Grand Tagabant in Beshquahoek is considering banning the festival and sending in the Eibar Tagabant to instil proper order to Qurol.

The official concerns are predictable. The gathering attracts heretics, promotes moral laxity, creates numerous opportunities for bad behavior, typically leads to a large uptick in unauthorized pregnancies, and opens the door to river-cult thinking. The unofficial concern is simpler: Qurol's festival joyously celebrates Fatune's light while making the New Authority look brittle, gloomy, and out of touch. When people leave the Riverwaq Festival, they carry memories of music and pleasure and creative freedom, all said to be in the light of Fatune. When they leave the Gleaming ceremonies in Beshquahoek, they carry memories of rigid protocol, uncomfortable kneeling, solemn chants and the smell of burning flesh that lingers in their clothes for days.

The Qurol town council has made it clear that banning the festival would be problematic. They've explained this in polite letters to the High Council at Beshquahoek, letters that convey a sense of absolute defiance while maintaining absolutely perfect formal courtesy. The festival generates enormous revenue, they note, a nice chunk of which always accompanies such letters. And it strengthens Fatunik cultural influence, they note, amongst the Riders, the Settans, and others. They suggest, without saying it is some many words, that the Festival demonstrates that faith in the Inextinguishable's promise for tomorrow need not be grim, that one can celebrate the light of Fatune in many ways.

What they don't say, because they don't need to is: try to shut this down and see what happens. Qurol pays its taxes to Center quickly

and at a higher rate than other towns. Qurol maintains order, after its fashion. There may be wild dancing, all-night partying and loud singing, but there are not speeches by heretics or uprisings by rabbit-sints. Qurol sends the Tagabant its quota of recruits. It manages the provinces villages and and it flies the Fatunik banners. But Qurol does things its own way. And the Center knows that some fights aren't worth picking.

The Organic Tower

Gallapoika, Qurol's Fatunik Representative, as she titles herself, leads the Town Council. She represents Qurol's particular genius for obeying the letter of Fatunik law while violating its spirit so thoroughly that even the spirit may be tempted to file a complaint. She's the only female top administrator of a Dominion town, and she likes to point out that nowhere in the Book of Heliodamus does it explicitly prohibit women from administrative service, that that kind of thing was developed by the Elders of Juuj in their commentaries. The brood structures, clothing restrictions and the fixed hierarchies required by the preaching of the Noonday Scribes? She argues in public that they should be followed meticulously.

In public, she often appears with her lovers next to her, all of them "appointed" by the Quroli Brooders Guild to accompany her. Her collection of Sellarunik silk scarves is enormous and she is known for wearing a different one almost every day. Her presentation flouts every norm of Fatunik female propriety. She wears her hair uncovered, cut short in a style borrowed from Rider women. Her robes are flowing, dyed in colors that would make a Beshquahoek Scribe clutch his chest. She walks the streets without male escorts, attends merchant council meetings on her own, wearing those scarves, and negotiates directly with Rider traders and Eelani mineral brokers.

When questioned about this by visiting Watchers from the Center, she produces elaborate arguments from the Book and from obscure Scribal texts demonstrating that her behavior is not only permitted but

actually encouraged, if one properly interprets Fatunik doctrine. Her arguments are nonsense, but very sophisticated nonsense built on cherry-picked quotes and logical gymnastics. They're delivered with such confidence and backed by well-paid Quroli Scribes who follow up on every word she says with such fierce determination that the Watchers from Beshquahoek eventually give up and file reports saying everything in Qurol is technically compliant.

She holds court in the Organic Tower's fifth-floor administrative chambers, rooms that have shifted slightly with the building's settling, creating floors that aren't quite level and walls that aren't quite plumb. Visitors from Beshquahoek and Byenung alike find the experience disorienting. Qurolians barely notice.

In Heliohlan, four hundred kilometers south in the Borda Woods province, the idea of a female administrator would be received with the kind of horror reserved for reports of wolf-sint attacks on brooder house nurseries. Heliohlan doesn't just follow Fatunik doctrine as adapted by the Beshquo Reforms. It believes it. Deeply. With the fervor of people who've seen what happens when order breaks down and chaos floods in with fire and smoke and the screaming of burning children.

The Memory of Smoke

The Great Conflagration happened three hundred years ago, but in Heliohlan they teach it to children like it was yesterday. Every household has stories. The Temmish brood lost seventeen members, incinerated in their village when the flames came. The ancestors of the Vosh brood house fled east with their clothes literally smoking. They settled in Heliohlan as refugees and never left. It is said that the Kollar brood stayed near the Ring and fought and died to the last man, woman, and child, defending their villages against the fire until there

was nothing left to defend.

The war had started from pride and ended in catastrophe. The Elders of Juuj thought they could suppress the Eelani, mountain-based miners and metal-workers who openly mocked Fatunik pretensions and refused and laughed when the Center announced that its Authority would apply to the Eelani highlands. The Tagabant, led by the fabled Eibar Battalion, marched into Eelan in their thousands, convinced that their numbers and faith would quickly overcome terrain and technology.

The Eelani had been preparing for exactly this type of stupidity for generations.

The passes were trapped. Rock slides buried entire companies. Arrows came from positions the Tagabant couldn't see, couldn't reach, couldn't answer. The mountain folk had access to advanced knowledge, techniques for refining metals and building weapons that made Fatunik equipment look primitive. They could communicate across vast distances, collapse tunnels on command, redirect rivers, and trigger avalanches that seemed like natural disasters until you noticed they always buried Tagabant positions.

A veteran Tagabant named Kur, now ninety-three and living in Heliohlan's veterans' quarters, remembers the stories his great-ones told him about what their grands had endured. He relates that his grand-grand had been sixteen when his unit marched into the Eelani highlands, and seventeen when he stumbled back out, one of maybe thirty survivors from a thousand-person cohort. He told of the sound of rocks falling in darkness, the screams of men suddenly buried alive, of the way his sergeant's head just disappeared when an Eelani sniper's shot found its mark.

But the Tagabant had kept coming. Relentlessly. The Dominion had population the Eelani couldn't match. For every company destroyed, two more were raised and sent forward. The Elders' strategy, if you could call it that, was simple: bleed the Eelani until they ran out of ammunition, ran out of tricks, ran out of energy. The frontlines held

with few changes for two turns, very, very slowly inching up the mountains. It was starting to work. Slowly, at terrible expense, but working.

That's when the Eelani turned to the Riders for help.

The Riders Council deliberated, as they always did, for longer than the Eelani would have liked. But eventually the Cann of Bordered agreed to organize assist the Eelani in exchange for closer alignment between their regions. Food convoys and weapons were sent. Fresh troops were promised. It was looking like the stalemate might turn in favor of the Eelani was turning, when the fire started.

Nobody knows how it began. The official Fatunik position is that the Eelani set it deliberately, sacrificing their own borderlands to stop the inevitable Tagabant advance. The Eelani claim that the Dominion, frightened to death of a direct conflict with the Riders, used barrels of oil from western Baranuk, that volatile substance that seeps from the ground and burns with terrible intensity, and that wind and accident spread the flames far beyond anyone's control.

What matters is that the entire borderland between Eelan and the Borda Woods became an inferno that burned for days.

The smoke was visible from Qurol, four hundred kilometers north. The ash fell like snow across the western provinces for weeks. Hundreds of villages on both sides were incinerated. The casualty numbers are disputed, but it is thought that something like twenty thousand, maybe more, mostly hum, died in the flames. The forests burned for days. Animals fled in every direction. Refugees streamed away from the conflagration in waves that overwhelmed every town and village within two hundred kilometers.

The Riders Council called both sides to negotiations in Bordered. A peace was imposed that has held, more or less, for three centuries.

Scars That Shape Faith

In Heliohlan, they remember all of it. It is their religion. The Beshquo Reforms were merely a confirmation of their faith. They teach their children about the Fire. They maintain monuments to the dead. The central temple has an entire wall covered in the names, carved in stone, of the people who burned. Reading the wall takes hours.

The Fatunik faith here isn't philosophical. It's visceral. The New Authority isn't abstract. It's salvation. It's the thing that stands between order and the hellscape of burning forests, screaming refugees, the smell of charred meat that used to be your neighbors. The Dominion's rules aren't oppressive. They're protective. The structure isn't stifling. It's absolutely necessary.

A young hum named Dowubra, with twenty-two turns of the light to her name, works in Heliohlan's communal nurseries. She was born here, raised here, has never traveled more than fifty kilometers from the town. Her great-great-greats survived the conflagration, bore children in the refugee camps, died in Heliohlan after teaching their descendants everything they remembered about the burning. And those stories were passed down, with no changes, precisely as they told, generation after generation, directly to Dowubra.

She believes. Not in the cautious, hedged way that educated Fatuniks in Beshquahoek believe, where they've read the Scribal arguments and can debate fine points of doctrine, comparing the Reforms to the old Juukal scrolls. She believes in the same way you believe in the force of gravity. The New Authority is right. The new structures are necessary. The barriers between pure hum and the modified and the animal-folk, between the true Fatuniks and the heretics, must be maintained because when they break down, Fatune does not forgive us. No, we burn.

She would never go to Qurol town. The very idea horrifies her. A female leader? Riders and Eelani mixing freely in the markets? Music and dancing that draws from non-Fatunik traditions? These aren't

creative freedoms. These are cracks in the wall. The first steps toward a maelstrom. It's bad enough that Settans are permitted to sell herbs in Heliohlan, but at least they don't stay for long.

When she hears that some Heliohlan residents long for the day when Tagabant armies once again sweep through the southlands, reclaiming lands that *should* be under Fatunik control, she understands the impulse even if she's uncertain about the practicality. It feels to her like healing. Like completing, at long last, what was started more than three hundred years ago.

The fact that such a campaign would fail miserably, that the southern tribes would no doubt unite and destroy any Tagabant force foolish enough to invade, that the Riders and Eelani and Nylanders would probably intervene, and the whole catastrophe would repeat itself, even worse... none of this penetrates. The longing isn't strategic. It's emotional. It's the desire to be strong enough that nobody ever threatens you again, that your children never again will ever have to flee from burning forests, that your descendants will never have to carve the names of thousands of martyrs into stone walls.

Pragmatists and Believers

On a summer evening in Qurol, the riverside fills with music. The Riverwaq Festival is two months away but performers are already practicing, testing new material on crowds of locals who've paid modest admission to watch rehearsals. A young singer has come all the way from a valley village in Juukal to perform a piece that blends traditional Fatune-greeting hymns with harmonies she learned from a Mobali fire-singer. The crowd applauds. A Watcher in the back makes a note in his report but doesn't intervene.

Gallapoika, the high administrator, the Fatunik Representative, sits on seventh-floor balcony of the Organic Tower, puffing on a small pipe of the Forghan Weed, watching the riverside and imagining the revenues. The festival will bring in enough to fund infrastructure

repairs for the next year. The aybets she'll sent to Beshquahoeck will keep the Center happy for another turn. The goodwill generated among Rider and Settan traders will strengthen Qurol's position as the Dominion's premier commercial hub.

This is loyalty, Qurol-style. Not emotional, not ideological. Practical. The Dominion provides security, legal frameworks, access to resources. Qurol provides revenue, military recruits, nominal obedience to doctrine. And something worth actually living for. Both sides get what they need. The arrangement works.

The question of whether this pragmatic loyalty can sustain the New Fatunik Authority long-term doesn't trouble Gallapoika much. She's a practical woman. Long-term is someone else's problem. Short-term, medium-term, Qurol has always thrived. That's enough. In the back of her mind lies the thought never spoken. The certainty that if Tonedor Rumpet was ever foolish enough to attack Qurol, she, like the miners of Eelan centuries before, would turn to the Riders Council, to the Cann of Bordered for rescue, and the tide would quickly turn in her favor...

In Heliohlan, four hundred kilometers south, the evening temple bells call the faithful to devotions. Dowubra leaves the nursery, walks to the nearest Fatunik temple, kneels with several hundred others in the perfectly aligned rows. The Scribe leads prayers thanking Fatune for the day's light, asking protection through the coming darkness, announcing their steadfastness in the leadership of the Grand Tagabant, reaffirming their commitment to the order that keeps mayhem at bay.

She believes every word of it. So do most of the folk around her. This isn't performance or social obligation. This is bedrock conviction, faith built on trauma and maintained through memory.

If you asked Dowubra whether pragmatic loyalty like Qurol's can also sustain the Authority, she'd look confused by the question. Loyalty isn't pragmatic. The Quroli are behaving badly, damaging the Dominion. They don't know. They didn't suffer like the Bordali of the

Woods. What is most essential is defending the light against the darkness. It's not a calculation. It's... survival.

Two Towns, One Dominion

The Dominion is large and it contains multitudes. Qurol and Heliohlan both fly the Fatunik banners and honor Tagabant fighters. Both send broodkins to the Watchers and to the Volunteers, though that is one area in which Qurol consistently lags behind. Both towns observe the formal protocols, pay their aybets to the Center, and acknowledge the Grand Tagabant's authority. Both are, technically, equally loyal.

But Qurol's loyalty is a merchant's bargain, renegotiable if the terms were to change. Heliohlan's loyalty is a survivor's reflex, absolute and unquestioning.

The Center in Beshquahoek needs both. The High Council needs Qurol's commercial success and its cultural flexibility. And it needs Heliohlan's unwavering faith and military commitment. It needs the pragmatists and the believers working in uneasy tandem, each compensating for the other's weaknesses.

The problem, if you're a hum like Tonedor Rumpet, trying to hold this sprawling, contradictory federation together, is that pragmatists and believers want different things. Qurol wants stability for commerce. Heliohlan wants purity through strength. Qurol sees the Riverwaq Festival as evidence the Dominion can evolve and thrive. Heliohlan sees it as evidence that the rot is spreading.

Both are right. But neither can admit it.

The Organic Tower at Qurol leans slightly in the evening breeze, its impossible architecture holding together through luck and momentum and the accumulated wisdom of generations of builders who knew when to stop asking why and just reinforce what works.

The Fatunik Temples at Heliohlan stand rigid in the gathering darkness, their perfect geometry a rebuke to bedlam, their spires rising up like spears, their stone walls covered with names that nobody's forgotten, that nobody is allowed to forget.

Fatune sets. The smoke from three hundred years ago is long dispersed. The memory lingers. And so does the music. Both are real. Both shape the Dominion's present, its future, its inevitable transformation.

The question isn't which approach is right. The question is whether they can coexist long enough for the coming transformation to be anything other than catastrophic.

The festival music carries on the river wind. The temple bells of Heliohan call the faithful to prayer. Two towns. Two faces of faith. One Dominion, straining at its seams.

The Candle and the Flame

The Grand Tagabant sleeps poorly these days. His private quarters in the administrative fortress adjacent to the Shining Temple are comfortable enough, luxurious by Fatunik standards. Silk sheets imported Settarune. Carpets thick enough to muffle footsteps. The sacred flame visible through a high window, burning eternally in the temple spire. Everything designed to project power, permanence, the inevitable triumph of order over chaos.

But at ninety-three, Tonedor Rumpet's nights are haunted. The Velkharim who attend him hear things through the heavy doors. Muttering. Sometimes what might be weeping, though that seems impossible. The Grand Tagabant does not weep. The man who ended the Kahila conflicts, who reformed the Dominion, who built Beshquahoek from a minor resort in a desolate grassland in ten years,

that man is beyond such weakness.

Still, the Velkharim hear what they hear. They say nothing, of course. Their tongues were cut out decades ago. They tend the old man, change his bedding, bring the hygioner's elixirs that smell of river mud and beetles. They watch him age in increments, the body failing while the will remains hard as iron.

Rumpet appears on the temple balcony for major ceremonies. Raises his hand in blessing. The crowd roars. He speaks maybe three sentences, voice still strong despite his age, and the faithful repeat his words like prayer. Then he withdraws back into the fortress, and the machinery of the Authority continues grinding forward, powered as much by momentum and institutional inertia as by any current direction from the top.

The question nobody asks aloud: what will happen when he dies?

The Boy from Rumpet Village

The official biography, taught in every Fatunik school, presents Tonedor Rumpet as born to purpose. A quiet, serious child from a small village in the Borda Woods. Father a minor Scribe, mother devout, family of modest means but impeccable loyalty. Showed early aptitude for scholarship. By age ten had mastered classical Eibar, could read the old texts, demonstrated the kind of focused intensity that marks future leaders.

Apprenticed to the Candle-Makers at age twelve. Not the prestigious Noonday Scribes, but the Candle-Makers, that austere order with a name that sounds like a guild, dedicated to bringing Fatune's true light into every corner of the Dominion. They were stern men, ascetic, suspicious of comfort and compromise. They studied at the Deep Pool in Juuj, gazing into those dark waters seeking visions of divine purpose.

Young Tonedor thrived under their discipline. Where other

apprentices chafed at the restrictions, the endless study, the requirement to root out heresy in oneself before seeking it in others, he seemed to welcome it. He learned control. Perfect, absolute control over every word, every gesture, every visible sign of weakness.

By sixteen he was giving private lessons to younger apprentices. By eighteen he was assisting in heresy investigations. By twenty he'd been appointed to the Candle-Maker's guild hall in Heliohlan, that militant town deep in the Borda Woods where faith runs hot and memory of the Great Conflagration still shapes every decision.

The official biography notes all this. What it doesn't mention is the particular vehemence young Tonedor brought to investigations of bloodline corruption. The way he seemed especially to take personal offense at the existence of modified hum, the mixt, of those whose ancestors had some animal-sint in them, of anyone whose purity could be questioned. Other Candle-Makers enforced doctrine because it was their duty. Tonedor enforced it like he was purging poison from his own body.

Ombrak Taladur and the Argument of Qadran

His mentor was a hum named Ombrak Taladur, senior Candle-Maker, stationed at the new guild hall in Beshquahoek when it was still just a minor village in Tablunque province, the location of some spas fed from underground and a remote Candle-Makers enclave, where they could study the old scrolls and develop their ideas for a more evangelical proclamation of Fatune's light. Ombrak was old even then, maybe seventy, with the kind of fierce certainty that either inspires absolute devotion or provokes violent resistance.

He taught Tonedor that faith without action was hollow performance. That the Dominion's weakness came from the Elders at Juuj being too compromising, too willing to accommodate heresy in the name of peace, too frightened to use the necessary force to suppress rebellion. The Kahila conflicts had dragged on for centuries, he told young

Tonedor, not because the Kahila were strong but because their Authority was weak.

Together they drafted the Argument of Qadran, a theological and political treatise from the Candle-Makers monastery in Beshqauhoek that condemned the passivity of the Juuj Authority and called for an all-encompassing, decisive, cleansing fire. The language was sophisticated, built on careful citations from the Book of Heliodamus and the commentaries, but the message was simple. Stop negotiating with heretics. Burn them out.

The of Argument of Qadran circulated through Candle-Maker networks for two turns before being presented to the Council of Elders at Juuj. The old ones read it, recognized its implications, and did what traditional authorities often do when confronted with radical proposals. They tried to suppress it. They declared it... inflammatory. Suggested Ombrak retire to a life of quiet contemplation. Reassigned young Tonedor to a remote posting in Mixrūn, a miserable town in Norgyte.

The Kahila radicals did Tonedor's work for him. They raided the Beshqauhoek guild hall, killed three Candle-Makers, and captured Ombrak Taladur. What they did to him took three days. When the body was finally recovered, it had been transformed into a message, a work of savage artistry that demonstrated exactly what the Kahila thought of Fatunik pretensions to authority. The statue that stands in the Shining Temple's rotunda honors Ombrak as the Solmar Qidarash, the Candle of Reckoning. It shows him at the moment of martyrdom, face raised toward Fatune's light, arms outstretched, robes flowing. It's beautiful, inspiring, and completely divorced from the actual horror of how he died.

Tonedor was twenty-two when he got word of the shape the body was in when it was recovered. Official accounts say he wept for two days. Then he vowed vengeance, dedicating himself to completing his mentor's work. What the accounts don't mention is the particular quality of his grief. The way it seemed less like sorrow for a lost teacher and more like fury at a stolen possession. How, when he

returned to Juuj with an army of Tagabant by his side, he touched the corpse's hand and whispered something nobody else could hear.

Within a month, he'd rallied the Candle-Makers and a devoted corps of hard-core Tagabant fighters. Within three months, he'd organized a coalition of younger Scribes and Tagabant commanders across the divisions who shared his contempt for the Juuj Elders' weakness. Within six months, he'd effectively staged a coup, not by seizing power directly but by making the old Authority at Juuj irrelevant.

The Beshquo Reforms began not as official policy but as facts on the ground, changes implemented by Tonedor's coalition that the Elders at Juuj couldn't reverse without triggering open conflict.

The Butcher of the Kahila Corridor

The campaign that ended the Kahila conflict was brutal beyond anything the Dominion had attempted before. It had the fury of the Great Conflagration, but this time the fires burned only in the direction of the Kahila Lands. The difference was not because previous Tagabant forces had been gentle. They'd been plenty violent. But Tonedor approached the problem differently.

Previous commanders had tried to occupy parts of Kahila territory, hold positions, and gradually extend control. Tonedor understood that this was impossible. The forests were too dense, the terrain too favorable to defenders, the Kahila too skilled at guerrilla tactics. So he didn't try to occupy. He set out to destroy.

His strategy was simple and horrific. Tagabant forces organized in unprecedented numbers swept through the corridor, the Kahilaqor, not trying to hold ground but to render it empty and uninhabitable. They burned villages. Poisoned wells. Destroyed food stores. Killed livestock. Cut down all the trees. Set fires. The goal wasn't conquest. It was to create such devastation that the Kahila would have no choice but to flee or starve.

A veteran named Matawa'ltre, who served in those campaigns, now has eighty-five turns to his name and lives in the Heliohlan veterans quarter. He doesn't talk about what he saw. When pressed, after enough s'lah, he'll say things like, "We followed orders." Or, "It was war." Or, "They'd been killing our folk for three hundred years."

What he won't describe is the screaming that still disturbs his sleep. The way entire villages were put to the sword because leaving survivors meant leaving future enemies. The stench of burning villages, burning bodies, burning forests. The Tagabant losses were bad. The Kahila fought desperately. But nobody came to their aid and the overwhelming numbers and ruthlessness of Rumpet's onslaught prevailed. The Kahila folk and the Kahila Lands were devastated.

Within eighteen months, nearly all of Kahilaqor, a big chunk of Kahilabeq, and even a slice of Kahilakol were turned into wasteland. The surviving Kahila populations fled deep into their eastern forests or to Settarune province on the other side of the Settan, into territories the Dominion couldn't reach without sparking a much broader conflict. The war ended not with treaties or negotiation but with exhaustion, with one side having demonstrated that it was willing to pay any price and inflict any horror to achieve victory.

Tonedor's enemies called him the Butcher of Beshquahoek. His supporters called him the Liberator of Juuj, claiming he'd freed the Dominion from three centuries of bleeding and disgrace. Both were right. The Kahila conflicts, at long last, had ended. The cost was bodies stacked in numbers that made most previous conflicts look restrained.

The New Authority

With the war over and his reputation established, Tonedor formalized what had been a creeping reality. He didn't abolish the old Council of Elders at Juuj. He simply moved the center of power and authority to Beshquahoek and reinvigorated old institutions that, in his view, had

become weakened through centuries of neglect.

The Grand Tagabant, a position that had previously been entirely ceremonial, now commanded all the military and policing and ideological forces of a much expanded organization. The High Council of the New Fatunik Authority centralized surveillance and enforcement. The Scribal Orders were reorganized too, with Candle-Makers elevated above the old Noonday Scribes and at the same time turned into an arm of the Meyajo Tagabant. The communal nursery system was expanded dramatically. An order went out to remove all children with fewer than ten turns from families, to be raised instead in the Authority's expanded network of Brooder Houses. Going forward, all procreation was to be the business of the Center.

He built the new capital. Beshquahoek had been a village of few thousand, taking care of visitors to the springs and serving the Candle-Makers enclave. Within ten years it was a city of sixty thousand, with those undulating walls, those curved streets radiating from the central plaza, its temple spire reaching higher than anything known in the Saskan Lands.

Thousands of workers, rotated in six-month shifts, building under conditions that killed many and maimed more. The official casualty figures are modest. The unofficial numbers, whispered in workers' quarters across the Dominion, are considerably higher. A master builder named Fuli, who worked on the southern wall section, remembers Tonedor visiting the construction sites. "He came maybe once every two months. Walked through, asked questions, listened to the engineers. He didn't smile. Didn't praise. Just looked at what we'd built, nodded, and left. But you could feel it. His vision. His will. The city rose up because he demanded it."

What Fuli doesn't mention: the section that collapsed during a storm, burying seventeen workers. Tonedor's response when informed: "Rebuild it. Better this time." No memorial. No compensation to families. Just rebuild it.

The city opened with ceremonies at the height of the summer heat and

lasted a week. The First Gleaming, they called it, that first great gathering where tens of thousands of faithful crowded the new plaza to witness the lighting of the sacred flame in the temple's spire. Tonedor stood on the balcony, raised his hand, and the crowd roared its approval.

He was maybe sixty-five then, still vigorous, still sharp. The man who'd ended the centuries-long conflict, reformed the Authority, punished the Kahila, built a capital that proved Fatunik power and permanence. At the apex of his influence, Tonedor Rumpet was commanding a level of resources and loyalty that previous leaders of Fatunik Authority could only dream of.

The Scribes of Beshquahoek describe it as the beginning of a new golden age. Less partisan observers might note it was also the beginning of an authoritarian contraction that's been tightening ever since.

The Machinery of Control

Tonedor's genius was understanding that true control requires systematization. It's not enough to have power yourself. You need to build institutions that exercise power automatically, that function without requiring constant personal intervention, that shape behavior through routine rather than drama.

The Watch expansion, the Tagabant reorganization, the Brooder system, the revived Volunteer program, the heretic burnings that became regular public spectacles rather than rare events, the crackdowns on bad thinking and bad behavior; it all created a system where control reproduces itself. Where people police themselves and each other because the machinery of surveillance is so omnipresent that resistance seems futile.

Nevertheless, systems built on fear and force have a particular fragility. They require constant maintenance. They break down when

the central will wavers or when circumstances shift faster than the machinery can adapt.

Tonedor is ninety-three. He still makes decisions, still issues directives through the High Council, still theoretically maintains absolute authority. But the day-to-day operation of the Dominion increasingly happens without his direct involvement. The High Council interprets his will. Provincial commanders implement their interpretations. Lower-level functionaries fill gaps, or not, according to their own judgment.

This is normal aging of an autocratic system. What makes it particularly dangerous in the Dominion's case is that Tonedor's authority is personal, not institutional. He's not the latest in a long line of Grand Tagabants following established precedents. He invented the role. His legitimacy flows from his own actions, his personal victories, his force of will.

When he dies, there's no clear succession mechanism. The New Authority could theoretically select a replacement. The senior Tagabant commanders could stage a military coup. The old Council at Juuj, or even Ingar for that matter, might try to reassert authority. Provincial powers might fragment. Any of these could happen. Or all of them could happen simultaneously. Fault lines already exist.

The Velkharim who attend Tonedor in his private quarters see an old man who sleeps poorly, who mutters in his sleep, who sometimes seems uncertain in ways he never was before. They can't speak, can't report what they observe. But they know. The machinery he built relentlessly grinds forward, but the architect of the New Authority is failing.

The Performance of Certainty

What's remarkable about Tonedor Rumpet, even now, is how completely he maintains the performance. Those rare public

appearances show no weakness. The hand raised in blessing doesn't tremble. The voice doesn't waver. He projects absolute certainty, perfect confidence, the inevitability of Fatunik triumph.

In private meetings with the High Council, he's still sharp. Still asks penetrating questions. Still makes decisions with the kind of finality that shuts down debate. The Council members leave those meetings believing the Grand Tagabant remains fully in control.

But the Velkharim hear what they hear at night. The muttering. The sounds that might be weeping. The way he sometimes wakes gasping, as if escaping from nightmares. The way he touches the statue of Ombrak Taladur in the temple rotunda before retiring each evening, fingers tracing the stone hand, shaking ever so slightly, whispering words they can't decipher.

There's a particular horror to watching someone who's built an entire system on the performance of strength begin to crack privately while maintaining the facade publicly. It raises questions about how much of the certainty was ever real. Whether the faith he's enforced so brutally is faith that he actually possesses or faith that he needs others to have because he lacks it himself.

He's spent sixty years implementing demands for absolute purity, total certainty, and unwavering commitment. No compromise with heresy. No accommodation of corrupted bloodlines. No tolerance for doubt. These aren't just political positions. They're existential absolutes backed by the authority of the Book of Heliodamus as interpreted by Scribes carefully selected for their reliability.

But there's a brittleness to absolute systems. They can't bend; only break. The more rigidly you enforce purity, the more terrifying it becomes when you discover impurity in yourself.

The Vanished Village

In all the official biographies of Tonedor Rumpet, the songs, the

elegiac hymns, the proclamations, posters, paintings, memorials and parades. In all the Noonday texts praising his rise and achievements, one detail appears only briefly. That he came from Rumpet village, a small settlement in the Borda Woods. Beyond that, nothing about his place of origin. The village itself is long gone, depopulated, its residents relocated to other areas, the land left for the Borda woods to reclaim. There are no monuments there, no markers. Nothing to indicate that it was once the childhood home of the Grand Tagabant.

Of course this isn't entirely unusual. Many small villages in the Borda Woods were abandoned after the Great Conflagration, or simply because populations shifted to larger towns. But the timing is notable. Rumpet village was depopulated about fifty years ago, during the early years of the Beshquo Reforms, just as Tonedor's was consolidating his power.

A old trader named Ele'eggl, who traveled through that region before the depopulation, remembers it as unremarkable. "Maybe two hundred people. Farmers, mostly. Some hunters. They grew vegetables, kept a few animals, paid their tithes. Nothing special about the place."

Asked if he remembered the Rumpet family specifically, Ele'eggl pauses. "There was talk. Nothing I'd repeat. Just talk." He won't elaborate.

Local records show the village's residents were not refugees. Rather, that they chose, or at least several dozen of them chose pretty much all at once to relocate to Heliohlan and nearby villages, where they were compensated for their property, somewhat oddly, by the local Candle-Makers guild, and quietly settled into new lives. This is probably true. Dominion records tend to be meticulous. But it's also true that meticulous records are sometimes created specifically to obscure what actually happened.

What's clear is that Tonedor never visits the site of his childhood home. Never mentions it in speeches. Never references his biological parents or extended family. The official biographies present him as

almost spontaneously generated, emerging fully formed from the Candle-Makers' training in Beshqauhoek with no messy personal history to complicate the narrative.

This kind of family erasure is not uncommon in the system of the New Authority; it is the model for the new unified huum society of the Dominion. All one big family under the all-encompassing light of Fatune. The personal past becomes inconvenient when you're trying to embody eternal principles. Better to be a symbol than a person, better to represent Fatune's will than to be someone's son.

But such erasure takes energy. Constant maintenance. And at ninety-three, with nights haunted by things the Velkharim can't speak about, the energy of forgetting becomes a bit harder to live with.

Succession

The High Council has begun discussing, very carefully, what happens after. They don't use that phrase. They talk about "contingency planning" and "institutional stability" and "ensuring continuity." But everyone knows what they mean.

There's no obvious successor. Tonedor never had a partner that anybody knew about, never brooded kin of his own, never groomed a protégé. The closest thing to an heir is the institutional machinery itself, the High Council and the Tagabant commands and the Watch bureaucracy. But machines don't provide legitimacy. They execute instructions. Without someone to give authoritative instructions, they might continue functioning on momentum, or they might fall into competing fiefdoms.

And of course there are those in the leading councils who are watching very carefully, waiting for their moment.

High Watcher Qonurk'lolhan, chair of the Council, ponders this problem late at night in his own quarters. He's seventy, been in service over forty turns, watched Tonedor build and expand the New

Authority. He strongly believes in the project. Mostly. Believes order is necessary. Believes the Dominion provides real security and stability that would collapse into a mess without strong central power.

But he also sees the ruptures. The overextension. The inevitable resistance building in the provinces. The younger generation questioning why the restrictions are necessary. The economic pressures. The external threats from Rider Arms and economic clout, from the armed rebellion of the Untamed, from the growing influence of the Mother of Fires, and from the vast populations of the wild southern tribes who aren't intimidated by Fatunik military power.

And he knows, though he'd never say it aloud, that Tonedor's particular brand of ruthless certainty was necessary to end the Kahila threat and to consolidate power. But he also know that it's exactly what's making the system increasingly fragile now. You can't maintain that level of control indefinitely. Eventually things that are too stiff will break if they don't learn how to bend.

The question is whether it will break while Tonedor is still alive to manage the aftermath, or whether it shatter later, when there's no one with enough personal authority to hold things together.

The Man Behind the Candle

Late at night, in the private quarters adjacent to the Shining Temple, Tonedor Rumpet lies awake. The hygioner's elixirs help sometimes. Sometimes they make the dreams worse. Clouds of incense rise to ward off moon-borne maladies. At least that's what the Scribes say, though he suspects it's mostly for the symbolic comfort.

He knows that he built something remarkable. A capital city that shouldn't exist, rising pure will. A military force that ended centuries of conflict. A system of control that reaches into every province, every town, every building. The Dominion he inherited was weak, fragmentary, perpetually on the edge of disintegration. The Dominion

he'll leave is powerful, centralized, and feared.

But at what cost? And for how long?

These aren't questions he allows himself during daylight. During the day he's the Grand Tagabant, the Liberator of Juuj, the Holder of the Candle of Reckoning. Absolute. Certain. Beyond doubt.

At night, the doubts come anyway. The memories of things he'd prefer to forget. The faces of people he ordered killed, not because they were threats but because they knew things, remembered things, represented complications, or simply represented a threat to his unquestioned primacy. At night, his own certainty sometimes feels like performance, like armor against something he can't afford to acknowledge.

The Velkharim bring fresh water, tend the incense, withdraw without sound. They've seen him age. They know things no one else knows, and because their tongues are gone, his secrets are safe. He touches his teeth with his tongue sometimes, feeling their shape, and remembers a boy by a village well, remembered words about bloodlines and corruption, and wonders if everything he's built is actually penance. Or revenge. Or proof.

Proof of what, he doesn't let himself articulate. Even in the privacy of his own skull, some thoughts are too dangerous.

The Candle Burns Down

The main metaphor that the Candle-Makers use is that faith is a flame, passed from candle to candle, each generation lighting the next. Tonedor has been the primary candle for sixty years. His flame burns so bright that his light reaches every corner of the Dominion.

But candles burn down. Eventually their wax is consumed and the wick is exhausted. The flame gutters and goes out, unless someone lights a new candle from the dying one. He hasn't lit that new candle.

Hasn't identified who would carry the flame after him. Maybe because he doesn't trust anyone. Maybe because he can't imagine the Dominion without him. Maybe because on some level he knows the flame he's carrying isn't the one that was passed to him, isn't the pure light of Fatune he claims to represent, but something else. Something that might not survive the transfer.

The sacred flame at the Shining Temple of Fatune in the center of Beshquahoek burns in the spire above his quarters. Eternal, they call it. The Inextinguishable. Tended by the Velkharim, fed with purified oil, never allowed to go dark. But Tonedor knows that eternal is just a word. Everything goes dark eventually. Civilizations collapse and everybody knows that. According to heretical theories whispered to him by spies returning from Terpinol, even the star-holes will close eventually. And even the light of Fatune will burn out one day.

The question isn't whether the light will continue. The question is what will burn to keep it going when he's gone. Whether the New Authority he built can sustain itself without his personal will to enforce it. Whether the system is strong enough to survive succession. Whether sixty years of brutal consolidation has created genuine stability or just delayed inevitable fragmentation.

He doesn't know. At ninety-three, haunted by dreams he can't quite remember upon waking, attended by servants who can't speak, isolated in luxury within the fortress adjacent to the temple whose construction required dozens of dead workers, he genuinely doesn't know.

What he knows: he's tired. The elixirs don't work like they used to. His hands shake slightly in private, though never in public. The dreams are getting worse, he insists that the incense burns all night. More and more the Velkharim hear things they'll never speak of.

What he knows is that for now the machinery keeps grinding. The Watchers patrol. The Tagabant drill. The Volunteers hunt and enforce. The heretics burn. The Authority functions.

What he fears, late at night when the doubts come is that it's all performance. That the certainty he's enforced so brutally is a certainty that he's never really possessed. That the purity he's demanded is a purity he's never personally achieved. That everything he's built is a wall against something inside himself that never stopped laughing at him, never stopped whispering his secrets, never stopped reminding him of what he's spent ninety years trying to destroy.

The candle burns. The wax melts. The flame flickers. Soon, one way or another, someone will need to light a new one. Whether there will be anything left to light it from remains to be seen.

The Old Authorities

With eight moons, the tidal patterns in the Krbsh Sea are a cacophony of movement. By the time there sloshing pushes back all the way to Ingar, it has become a wave strong enough to reverse the course of the river for a few hours. Although Ingar is 250 kilometers from Pavan Bay, the tides of the Krbsh Sea, driven by eight moon, westerly winds, and underground currents affect the Pavan River in strange ways all the way up to Ingar, where slightly brackish water laps against stone foundations laid fifteen hundred years ago. The sound of the river fighting back against the powerful slosh of the tides is constant, rhythmic, never quite consistent and utterly indifferent to hum concerns.

Ingar is the original Fatunik settlement, the place where refugees from the great migration first gathered around the Book of Heliodamus and decided that a hum order was worth fighting for. Ingar still spills down cliffs overlooking the Pavan River and flows into docks that have handled traffic from upriver and downriver, it seems now, since time immemorial.

But the Jewel of Eibar stands humbled now. Not as the Center of Fatunik Authority. That designation moved inland to Juuj over a thousand years ago, then shifted again to Beshquahoek sixty-five years back. Now Ingar is a provincial town technically subject like all Dominion towns and villages, to the New Fatunik Authority in Beshquahoek, paying tribute and sending its broodkins to the Watchers and the Volunteers. But it is provincial in a way that carries a good deal more weight than any other town in the Dominion, perhaps more than any other town in all the Saskan Lands. Ingar is provincial like a matriarch whose children have moved away but who still expects deference when they visit.

Walk the old streets nearest to the river and you'll smell fish before you smell incense. Hear merchants haggling in a dozen dialects before you hear Scribal chanting. The Watchers here, yes, but they move carefully, aware that their authority is more negotiated than absolute. This is where the Dominion began. The stones remember.

Approach the bridge over the Pavan and the walls of the old town and marvel at the sight of the monumental statues of the Seven Titans, a testament to the extraordinary drive of the early settlers, to their determination to make this the new land of the hum folk.

An bent-over old woman carrying eighty-seven turns sits most days on a bench near one of the Titans, the enormous ancient statues covered in moss and vines, guarding the approach to Ingar since a few years after the arrival. The Titans are the first great monuments of a new civilization. For Johpa, the giant statue is just part of the landscape. She likes to sit here because this one is her favorite. She remembers when the Grand Tagabant visited Ingar as a boy, she claims, though she would have been just a child herself. "He came with his father to see the library in the Great Holly Tower," she says. "Serious little thing. Didn't smile. Didn't play with the other children. Just looked at everything like he was memorizing it."

She pauses, pulling her shawl tighter against the wind. "His father kept him close. Didn't let him talk to locals. Like we had something catching." She laughs, a dry sound. "Maybe we did." Then in a

whisper, "There is a song from Pavanoa that says freedom is catching, if you spend too long by the waters." And she laughs again.

The Holly Tower

Its close integration with the Pavan river and its connection to the sea and to Pavanoa town, Ingar's sister by the sea, makes Ingar feel different, even though it is more than a couple of hundred kilometers inland. The river is still very wide at Ingar. Ships arrive coming up the river. From Mobalbesq. From the Ny Lands. Sometimes even from beyond the Krbsh Sea, bringing trade, news, and ideas that the Authority would prefer to filter only through official channels. The Port Watchers and Riverwaq do their jobs, checking cargo manifests, looking for prohibited items. But the sheer volume of trade makes comprehensive control impossible. And the slippier routines of riverside docks have been honed over almost two millennia into a fine art. Things slip through. Books from foreign lands. Mechanical devices. Medicines that work better than approved Fatunik remedies. Weapons.

To this day, the Holly Tower of Ingar houses the Dominion's most extensive library, with collections that predate the transfer of Authority to Juuj. The Holly Tower library hosts texts that the Noonday Scribes of Beshquahoek don't know exist, safely hidden in vaults to be opened only when the time is right. The tower librarians are a quiet cadre of scholars who've held their positions for generations upon generations; it is by far the oldest scribes organization in all the Saskan Lands. They maintain elaborate card catalogs, and keep access to some sections restricted while following, as far as anyone can see, all the formal procedures required by the Watchers of the New Authority -- along with a whole set of procedures of their own.

The local systems handled by the librarians are carefully guarded. A researcher holding forty-three turns has worked in the restricted sections of the Holly Tree library for thirty-two years. He was

apprenticed into the trade by his father and he has never been seen by any visiting officials from the Center. He knows which texts are actually dangerous, which are merely labeled that way for bureaucratic reasons, and which are modified copies to be shown to certain qualified visitors. He knows which Scribes are genuinely interested in scholarship and which are looking for evidence of heresy. He knows how to say "I'm terribly sorry to have to tell you that that text has been lost" in ways that mean entirely different things to different listeners.

Last month an enthusiastic young Scribe from Beshquahoek arrived requesting rare astronomical texts. After being vetted by an array of librarians in the outer stacks, the pale man in the restricted section where he'd been directed explained, quite truthfully, that such materials are restricted and could only be requested by a much more senior Scribe. He suggested some approved alternative readings from the commentaries. The Scribe left disappointed. Three days later, as he was waiting to board a boat upriver at a tavern frequented by ship crews, he happened to have a conversation with a well-spoken Ingari about the weather, the complex system of tides, and about the moons and the stars that sailors from Pavanoa use for navigation.

No prohibited texts had changed hands. No heresy had committed or level of bureaucracy violated. Just two hum in a tavern discussing the sky over s'lah. If the young Scribe left Ingari with a broader understanding of astronomy than the approved Fatunik doctrine allows, and if he carried with him a sense that while Ingari might be difficult to understand, and its folks a bit strange, well, they say that the air moving across the turbulent waters of the Pavan in that region can do strange things to perspective.

Despite the infamous Eibar Battalion being named for the province, the entire Tagabant garrison at Ingari is small, no more than two hundred soldiers, mostly involved in organizing defenses further north against incursions from Ilyushan. They're not zealous units working with Watchers or Volunteers to ferret out heretics. They're practical soldiers who understand that rigid enforcement of unpopular

laws in a city like Ingar is futile. So they collect their pay, do their drills, spend their time on matters that actually matter to the safety of the province, and look the other way at the countless small deviations from perfect orthodoxy.

Their commander is not afraid to state plainly: "You want to control Ingar, you control the docks and the warehouses. You want safety in Eibar, you patrol the Rocking River and the western approaches to the Ilyushan Range. Everything else is performance. The New Authority gets its tribute. We maintain basic order and security. We support the Holly Tower and our merchants make money. Everyone's happy. Happy enough."

This kind of pragmatism is exactly what horrifies the High Council in Beshquahoek. Regular reports from their appointed Watchers suggest Ingar is probably a hotbed of potential heresy, requiring increased surveillance and enforcement. But actually verifying such reports is nearly impossible. Implementing harsh enforcement would disrupt trade, alienate the guilds, and drive seaborne commerce to other ports beyond Fatunik control. So the reports circulate and the High Council expresses concern, but nothing changes and Ingar carries on as it always has.

Ingar persists. Ancient. Deeply connected to the mountains, to the river, to the sea. Its language is the langue of the Dominion, of the huum folk. It is independent in ways that don't require open defiance. The tides push impossible currents up to its docks hundreds of kilometers up-river. Ships arrive from both directions. Merchants from all the lands exchange goods and information, as they have always done. The librarians in the Holly Tower preserve knowledge that the Center would prefer lost, if they knew it was there. And the Seven Titans stand watch, covered in moss, patient as stone, waiting, perhaps, for another change in the light.

The Heart of Fatune

Three hundred kilometers inland from Ingar, well south of the Pavan River and well north of the Settan, but only 75 kilometers east of the western barriers of the Kahilakol, the Fatunik town of Juuj maintains a different form of quiet resistance. This was the Dominion's beating heart for five hundred years, the seat of the Council of Elders, the place where the Deep Pool's dark waters were consulted for divine guidance. The Authority passed to the Elders long before Tonedor Rumpet. Long before the Beshquo Reforms. Centuries before the Center moved to the new capital with its gleaming walls and perfect geometry.

Juuj didn't fight the transition to Beshquahoek. Couldn't, really. The military power had spoken in blood and fire. The political momentum was clear. The Council of Elders formally acknowledged the New Authority, blessed the construction of Beshquahoek, and sent representatives to the First Gleaming. Everything proper and correct.

But the Elders still meet in the same cavern-temple where they've met for over five centuries. They still conduct the old rituals, still consult the Deep Pool, still maintain the institutional memory of a time when the Dominion was governed differently, when Authority was matter of wisdom, not control.

Silvana, with seventy-nine turns, has served the Deep Pool her entire life and has sat and consulted with the Council of Elders for over forty-three turns. She knows that the Council's decisions once actually mattered.

"We still make decisions," se says carefully, sitting in her study nestled into the Juukal forest, a tangle of vines and massive rhododendrons a couple of clicks from the cenote. "Of course, we still govern Juukal province and we still interpret doctrine and settle disputes. We still review the Arguments sent here from Byenung and elsewhere. The New Authority hasn't abolished us. Even if they reject all of the Arguments."

She pauses, fingers tracing the rim of bowl of s'lah. The porcelain is old, delicate, decorated with ancient patterns that would be considered

frivolous in Beshquahoek. "We've just been... put to the side while the Grand Tagabant handles more pressing matters."

It's a diplomatic way to say what's happened. The decisions of the Council of the Elders of Juuj on local matters are still implemented, more or less. Their governance of Juukal province continues as it has for centuries, except... for in the many new Tagabant camps created at the time of the occupation of Kahilaqor. And of course anything touching larger Dominion policy, anything involving military matters or inter-provincial coordination or ideological enforcement, that all goes directly through Beshquahoek now.

The interesting thing is what the Council does with the freedom this irrelevance provides. They continue to interpret doctrine more flexibly than the Candle-Makers in Beshquahoek allow for. They maintain contact with Scribal communities across the Dominion, both inside and outside the Fatunik lands, who share their concerns about the New Authority's direction. They know better than to formally accept any of the Byenung Arguments. Each one of them is offered a denial in the time-honored ways. But they continue to receive the Runik couriers and to keep copies of the scrolls they have been receiving for hundreds of years. Nobody knows how deep the vaults around the Deep Pool extend. The Elders have been annotating commentaries and collecting Argument for hundreds of years. They are well aware of how the Dominion functioned before, knowledge that might become relevant again if circumstances were to change.

They're not rebels. They're not plotting coups. They're not even a major trading center like Ingar. Juukal has a small population with little industry. It sends fewer youths to the Watchers and the Volunteers than any other province. But in their own quiet way, keeping alive a tradition that is held deeply in soul of the Fatunik folk, and preserving the possibility that Fatunik governance could look different than what Tonedor Rumpet has built.

The Deep Pool itself still receives visitors. Even Candle-Makers come to consult it, seeking visions of Fatune's will in its dark water. For the most part, the Council no longer controls who is allowed access

through the main gates. That's regulated by Watchers from Beshquahoek now, But the Pool itself remains as it always has. Silent. Deep. Older than the Dominion. Older than any current controversy. Night Hall scholars are not afraid to say that it is older than Fatune.

And others still come too, bypassing the eyes of the Watchers, using the old tunnels connecting to cave entrances located dozens of kilometers away, routes that were never reported to the New Authority, leading to observation points around the Pool that can't be seen from the other side. There is a small room in the stacks deep in the lower chambers of the Night Hall Library devoted exclusively to the underground caverns of Juukal. In it, very old maps show rivers and tunnel running far beneath the central range of hills that connects Juukal, Tablunque and the Borda Woods.

A young Candle-Maker from Beshquahoek visited the Deep Pool last month. He gazed into the water for hours, seeking guidance about doubts he couldn't articulate clearly. What he saw, or thought he saw, and what he heard, he didn't discuss with anyone upon his return to shining city. But he left Juuj troubled, for the first time in his life, uncertain, asking himself questions his training had not prepared him for.

This is what Juuj does now. It doesn't challenge. It doesn't confront. It just exists, patient as the Deep Pool itself, preserving memory and letting possibility percolate to the surface. If the New Authority proves sustainable, Juuj will adapt, will remain a provincial town with an illustrious past. If the New Authority collapses, Juuj has the institutional framework standing by to step back into significance.

The Council of Elders meets. They chant and pray. They deliberate. They study the Arguments. They write their commentaries. They govern their province. They wait.

The Distant Province

Far to the east, where the Dominion's reach attenuates to nearly nothing, Pavanarune province maintains the most tenuous relationship with central authority of all the Fatunik provinces. The province is not small in geography, and even larger in the imagination of many. It stretches from the Kahila forests to the Krbsh Sea coast, encompassing diverse populations who never fully accepted any kind of centralized Fatunik control long before the Beshquo Reforms made that control more burdensome.

The main town of Pavanarune, Pavanoa, sits on the bay, in the broad delta where the Pavan River meets the sea. It's a trading hub, prosperous and cosmopolitan in ways that makes Beshquahoek Scribes nervous. Ingar's "little sister" is the oldest port in the Saskan Lands. The markets of Pavanoa sell goods from across the Saskan Lands and beyond. Though typical Fatunik separation of the species is maintained, its population includes openly visible sints, modified folk, and Jaxen.

The Tagabant presence here is minimal. Maybe five hundred soldiers for the entire province, spread across multiple garrisons, vastly insufficient for actual enforcement of Fatunik orthodoxy. Most are either based in and around Ríkila or, like their compatriots in Ingar, focus most of their attention organizing frontier patrols against attacks from Ilyushan. The Pavanoa Dorq Tagabant and Riverwaq maintain appearances. They check papers at key checkpoints. Provide security for official ceremonies. Keep watch on any developments that might echo the Event in Ríkila. Beyond that, Pavanarune governs itself according to traditions that predate the Dominion's expansion into the rest of the Saskan Lands, indeed that predate the use of the term Dominion.

Where the Dominion has sought to expand north, west and south, Pavanoa has always maintained its gaze eastward, out towards the sea. A merchant named Tollek, sixty years old, runs a shipping business from the Pavan docks. He pays his fees to the Town Council, maintains correct documentation, and flies Fatunik banners from his warehouse. In every legal sense, he's a loyal subject of the Dominion.

He also facilitates inland trade with the Kahila territories and down the coast to the Mobalbesq communes. His team moves goods that the Authority would prefer didn't circulate. He maintains contacts with networks that the Watchers would call heretical, if they knew about them. He sees no contradiction in any of this. "The Authority wants taxes and public order," he says. "They get both. What else otherwise is just good business."

This attitude is common in Pavanarune. Nominal loyalty combined with practical autonomy. The forms are observed. The substance is negotiable. The only Volunteers in Pavanoa are in the old style, that is, neighbors who join together to make repairs and townspeople who will rush to the border with pitchforks, knives and cudgels if the Tagabant issues a warning of trouble at the border.

The problem with Pavanoa, from the New Authority's perspective, is that it clearly demonstrates an alternative is possible. And free-wheeling Pavanoa town is not the only problem. One hundred and fifty kilometers inland, nestled between the great wall of fallen trees surrounding the Kahilakol and Mobali border, lies the town of Ríkila, which makes Pavanoa look like a well-behaved sibling.

The entire province is proof that even inside the Dominion Fatunik identity doesn't require the kind of rigid enforcement that Beshquahoek insists on. That you can be loyal to the Inextinguishable without burning heretics or terrorizing your population into compliance.

In Pavanarune, even more so than in Ingar, the old ways of the original Eibar folk never went away. Twenty turns back, this alternative example became painfully explicit in Ríkila town.

The Event in Ríkila

Ríkila sits on the south-western tip of Pavanarune province, at a natural crossroads between the Dominion, the Kahila lands and the

Outer lands. It's old, nearly as old as Pavana, originally built on top of long-buried foundation stones that nobody ever fully understood. Not runes, like in the Rune of Bye. Something else. Huge, monumental slabs. The town has always been a mixing point, a place where Fatunik and Kahila and Mobali populations have traded with each despite centuries of war and distrust, where rules have long been more suggestion than absolute.

Twenty years ago, the New Authority decided this was intolerable.

The details of what sparked the Rising are disputed. The official Fatunik version blames Kahila agitators, foreign troublemakers, and heretical elements that had infiltrated the town. Local accounts speak of Tagabant overreach, arbitrary arrests, crackdowns that pushed too hard on populations already resentful of Beshquahoek's distant authority.

What's clear is that fighting erupted. Not skirmishes: sustained urban combat, massive demonstrations, buildings burning, streets barricaded, running battles, Tagabant barracks attacked. Hundreds died in the uprising. The local Dorq Tagabant garrison got pinned down, besieged in their own barracks. Reinforcements arrived from Rutónik but found themselves in a grinding stalemate.

The fighting continued sporadically for months. The western quarter, further from the Ring Road and closer to the Mobali frontier, eventually became rebel-held. The eastern quarter and the main gate remained under Fatunik control. The bazaar district, the commercial heart of the town, became a no-man's land where both sides raided and neither could hold, with the rebels gradually establishing dominance there as well.

Then, quiet as the night, following one particularly bloody episode in the main plaza, the Beqawar arrived.

To this day, nobody in Ríkila seems to be entirely sure who the Beqawar are or where they came from. They claim to be from the far western fringes of the Saskan Lands, places so distant they're barely

rumors, from a place most Saskan folks call High Weir, although the Beqawar, when they could be convinced to say anything, said represented what they referred to as the High Tables of the Empafarasi. They came heavily armed in ways that no one had ever seen before. Even the Riders were a bit shocked. And they are highly disciplined, highly skilled and apparently uninterested in taking sides. They imposed a ceasefire, established checkpoints between the two halves of Ríkila, and announced they would maintain the peace until both sides negotiated a settlement.

Initially there was some fighting, especially with the Tagabant, who dared to attack the Beqawar and managed to kill two of them. The next day, the Tagabant garrison exploded, destroying it entirely, killing dozens of Fatunik warriors and wrecking buildings all over the eastern quarter.

Twenty years later, they're still there. A settlement was never negotiated. Ríkila remains divided. The Fatunik side maintains its allegiance to Beshquahoek, more or less. The rebel areas of the town operates under a loose coalition of Kahila romperi, local councils operating on something like a Mobali communal model, and whatever authority the inhabitants of each block choose to recognize day to day.

And in the rebel-held bazaar, at the end of narrow winding lanes where even Beqawar patrols are not visible, sits the Inn of the Full Moons.

The Inn of the Full Moons

The entrance is unremarkable. A wooden door in a stone building that looks like a dozen others in the labyrinthine bazaar. You wouldn't find it by accident. People who need to find it, find it. People who don't walk past without even noticing it.

Once inside, a towering barkeep greets arrivals with a booming

command: "S'lah!" Not a suggestion. You buy the house specialty or you leave. Once you've paid, once you've demonstrated you're here for business not trouble, the giant nods toward the depths of the tavern, and you are permitted to enter a space that seems larger than the building containing it should allow.

The noise is constant. Babble of conversation in a dozen dialects and languages, deals being made, assignments arranged, information traded. The smell is smoke and sweat and cooking roots and meat and something else, something that might be magic except of course that magic doesn't exist.

The owner, Kirill Geckster, is a gecko-sint. This alone would be remarkable, not only the first non-huum to own and manage a major establishment inside the Dominion's nominal territory, but a pint-sized gecko-sint at that. And Kirill is remarkable beyond his strange appearance. He is known as the Master of the Manifold Ways for his network of connections spanning the Saskan Lands and beyond. He's made the Inn into a hub for activities of all kinds, some of which are perfectly legal. The Inn offers lodging for travelers, secure warehousing for goods, meeting spaces for merchants. It's particularly famous for its octo-sint barkeepers, whose multiple limbs can mix drinks with spectacular efficiency, and for its regular rotation of amusing bards and entertainers.

Other activities are less legal. The Inn is a sanctuary for people whom the Authority would arrest on sight if they could get to them. It is a clearinghouse for information that any Watcher would prefer suppressed. A gathering point for what the New Authority calls heretics and what the inhabitants call simply "people who disagree with Rumpet".

The architecture itself seems to shift. Corridors that lead different places depending on when you walk them. Rooms that feel like they appear and disappear. There are even stories of hidden passages reaching tunnels that go all the way to the sea, and of chambers where denizens of Krbsh undersea realms conduct mysterious business. Of

spaces that exist slightly sideways from normal reality.

Most of this is probably exaggeration, tricks of light and clever construction. Probably. But the Inn has quite a reputation, and reputation shapes reality in its own ways. A trader named Vessa stayed at the Inn three months ago. She'd come from the central Settan Lands with a cargo of textiles. Legitimate business. But she'd also been asking questions about someone whom the Fatunik authorities wanted found. The Watchers had noticed and were preparing to detain her for interrogation.

She also mentioned this to a contact in the bazaar, who gave her directions to the Inn. She found the unremarkable door, drank her s'lah, got shown to a room on what might have been the third floor or might have been the fifth, where she had accommodations for four days. When she emerged, the Watchers had moved on to other concerns, her cargo was delivered, her business was completed, her questions were still mostly unanswered, but also unpunished.

"The Inn protects folks in Ríkila," she said carefully when asked about her experience. "What it protects you from, what it costs... those are things you figure out while you're there. But yeah. That's what I would say. That it protects."

The Rising

Ríkila's division represents the New Authority's most visible failure. Not a military defeat. The Tagabant could have recaptured the eastern quarter if they'd been willing to destroy it completely, if they had acted quickly and decisively before the Beqawar showed up. But a political acknowledgment was made that some things can't be controlled, that pushing too hard could break more than it fixes, and by then it was too late. The Empafarasi had made their move.

The Beqawar presence prevents the stalemate from reigniting into open combat. Their checkpoints between the quarters are manned by

highly professional, highly skilled soldiers who answer to no one except the Empafarasi lord they call Khar-Mael. They let people cross both ways after checking papers. They ask few questions; mostly just give those crossing a long, cold stare. They prevent any large-scale military actions from developing. Everybody remembers what happened to the Tagabant garrison. The Beqawar maintain, if not peace, then at least the absence of active conflict.

And they scare the fuck out of absolutely everyone, which sort of suits both sides. The Fatunik quarter maintains its connection to the Dominion, its trade relationships, its formal allegiance. The rebel side maintains its autonomy, its connections to the Kahila territories and to the Mobali communes, and its freedom from Beshquahoe's oversight.

The bazaar, though rebel-held, works the space between, a gray zone where both sides mingle and trade. Merchants from both sides mix freely there and goods flow both directions, but there are no Fatunik Watchers. The Beqawar occasionally patrol the market, but they never interfere with commerce, stepping in only when a street scuffle looks like it might escalate.

A young vendor, maybe twenty-two turns to her name, sells fresh roots and seagrass in the bazaar. She sources them from both the Fatunik provinces, from Mobalbesq and, through some circuitous contacts made in Morilly, the Kahila forest. Her stall sits close enough to a Beqawar checkpoint that she feels safe from harassment by either side. "They all leave me alone," she says, arranging the dried roots on her display table. "I sell to Fatunik loyalists and to rebels. They all know I look to the Beqawar for protection. I've tried offering the Beqawar money, but they won't take it. They barely talk at all. When they do, it's practically impossible to understand their dialect." Then in a whisper, "The Master knows that I provide useful cover for people crossing into town from breaches in the western wall, so I don't pay a tax to the rebels. These days, everyone gets what they need if they remember not to push too hard."

This is Ríkila in microcosm. A negotiated balance based on mutual

exhaustion and pragmatic accommodation. Not peace, exactly. Not resolution. A functional stalemate.

But functional stalemate is still a form of failure for a Fatunik Authority that claims absolute legitimacy. Every day Ríkila remains divided is a day that demonstrates the Rumpet's control is partial, that alternatives exist, that rebellion hasn't been completely crushed.

Fractures

In Ingar, the old capital, timeless operations of all kinds bide their time while maintaining formal loyalty. In Juuj, the Council of Elders preserves institutional memory. In Pavanoa, practical autonomy substitutes for theoretical obedience. And in Ríkila, open rebellion persists despite the Authority's best efforts.

These aren't coordinated zones of resistance. They're not plotting together or planning uprisings. They're just adapting to local conditions, finding space within or adjacent to the New Authority's structures. Maintaining alternatives. But alternatives accumulate. Each successful adaptation demonstrates that the Authority's absolutism is negotiable. Each compromise with places like Pavanoa and Qurol and even Khālo suggest that rigid enforcement isn't actually necessary for Fatunik identity to persist.

The High Council in Beshquahoek watches this erosion with increasing alarm. Reports circulate about Ingar's lax enforcement, about secrets that the ancient Council of the Eibar Folk is keeping from the Center. About Juuj's doctrinal flexibility. About moral corruption in Qurol and financial shenanigan in Khālo. About the foreigners walking about without being watched in Pavanoa and Ríkila's open defiance. Proposals emerge for sending in more undercover Meyajo agents, for crackdowns, increased surveillance and military enforcement. Implementing such measures would require financial and personnel resources the Authority doesn't have to spare. It would mean treating one of the oldest Dominion provinces and

several of its most profitable towns like an enemies. It would risk turning simmering resentment, currently under control, into active rebellion.

So the reports circulate, concern is expressed, and mostly nothing changes.

Meanwhile, in the private quarters adjacent to the Shining Temple, the Grand Tagabant sleeps poorly. The Velkharim hear what they hear. The machinery grinds forward. The candle burns down. And in the old centers, in the places where Fatunik identity was forged many centuries before Tonedor Rumpet reshaped it, the Eibar folk and the Elders of Juuj watch and wait.

The tidal waves lap at the mossy stones of Ingar. The Council of Elders still meets around the Deep Pool in Juuj. Ships dock at Pavana carrying goods and ideas from beyond. Lanterns in the Inn of the Full Moons glow all night, deep within Ríkila's divided bazaar, making space for everyone who arrives. Loyal Fatunik folk dance with mad abandon on the shores of the Pavan in Qurol. These are the old foundations and newly opened spaces. Old stone that have weathered centuries of storms. Old trees that bend in the wind. They bent when Beshquahoek rose. They accommodated the New Authority's demands. They maintained their forms while adjusting their substance.

When the transformation comes, when the fragile systems built on absolute certainty finally crack open, these foundations might prove more durable than the gleaming walls of Beshquahoek. Old pillars might once again support something new. Something that draws on Fatunik traditions while releasing the brutal grip that's characterized the last sixty years.

Or they might not. The future is unwritten. The Deep Pool in Juuj reveals visions, but visions require interpretation. The tidal slosh of the river at Ingar moves according to the complex rhythm of the moons, those eight holes in night's fabric that the orthodox doctrine claims are sources of darkness, but that sea-folk have navigated by for

generations.

What's certain is that the old centers still endure. Patient and inpatient. Flexible. Maintaining memory and possibility. Seeing what is growing from the cracks. The stones remember. The tide keeps its multi-part rhythms. The Elders deliberate. The Inn of the Full Moons creates new meeting spaces.

And somewhere in Beshquahoek, in the perfect geometry that's supposed to be eternal, the foundations are settling unevenly and a something is corroding beneath the gleaming plaza while the transformation builds up pressure.

Soon, one way or another, something will break. The question is what grows from the breaking. Whether the old centers become foundations for renewal or ruins marking the collapse of the Fatunik Dominion.

The tidal waves push and the river pushes back. The stones endure. The future will arrive whether anyone's ready or not.